Hearts of Glass

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/55704067.

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Mature

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Graphic Depictions Of Violence

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

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Angst, Heartbreak, Soul-Searching, Friendship/Love, Childhood Trauma, Implied/Referenced Child Abuse

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Part 3 of The Moments Between

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by Faded_Glory

Summary

(A companion piece to Tapestry of Time) Adora and Catra's lives are forever changed when Adora finds the Sword. They go their own ways and seek to forge their own destines apart.
This is only the beginning of their journey back to each other.

Notes

Thankyou PinkStorm for your comment and all those who left kudos. Also thankyou Idiotevelynlol, it is not a bad ending that story leads into this one and eventually to my main Fic Tapestry of Time.

See the end of the work for more notes

The End of what was

S1:E1, E2:The Sword

Catra

The feline had retreated to her perch atop the platform near the Forge. As soon as Adora had taken off, knowing she needed to be absent from the bunkroom before the morning roll call. Plausible deniability was the key to keeping Adora's whereabouts secret. When Shadow Weaver found out Adora had gone Awol….again. At least it would be enough to delay the inevitable punishment Catra would receive, when the old witch lost her temper about losing her precious Adora.

Her time incarcerated in the Disciplinary Barracks just last season had left a very unsavory mark upon her already rather fragile sense of safety. She was even more wary about stepping out of line, now. At least more sneaky, more cunning so that her little rebellions against her Superior Officer's. She would never get caught again. Adora was Force Captain now, she had taken that first step towards real power. Adora would promote her up as well. Catra would be her second in command of Red Squadron, when they all graduated. Just like she was growing up, then things would start to change around here. That hope burned in her heart, a raw, kindling bursting inside of her that her life was going to get better now. The long years of waiting were over… Adora would finally have the power to keep safe.

This was just a little hiccup, Adora would be back…she had to be!

Catra crouches upon the forward railing of the platform she and Adora retreat to when they want to be alone. Drawing her knees

tight to her chest. Brooding over Adora's latest act of 'heroism'. Her keen night vision, catching sight of the glowing back thruster of the skiff in the distance beyond the base's eastern ramparts. Keeping track of the skiff, until it faded out of view on the barren horizon. Her thoughts reviewing that last exchange, bitterly. As a cold lump of foreboding grew in stomach, making her feel queasy. With a restless, anxious sort of energy. That made her ear's twitch and her tail bristle. As she was desperate to figure out why Adora would not take her? It made no sense…to leave her behind? Why…the question plagued her like a slow poison. They were a team…?

"Hey, where are you going?" Catra called out, in a harsh whisper. Following Adora out of the bunkroom. Not wanting to draw attention to either of them, since they were out of bed in the middle of the night. The corridor patrol bot's were always close by. She could hear their tell-tale twitters and beeps, just a few intersections away.

"I need to go back to the woods, there is something I have to figure out." Adora returned, as she finished buckling her belt.

"What..you're not,,," Catra started to complain, before Adora slammed her hand over her mouth and dragged her out of sight behind a support column. Just as a patrol bot rolled around the corner of the intersection just ahead. The stout, bulbous looking bot. Taking its route down the corridor, beeping and twittering past their hiding spot.

Catra's eyes went wide in alarm, but as soon as the bot got further down the corridor. She wiggled free of Adora's hold, her glare hot and accusing.

"What is wrong with you? You have been acting weird since we got back? Are you sure you're not brain damaged?" She reached out and grasped Adora's chin in one hand the other cupping the side of her head in mild concern. It wasn't so far-fetched with the

bad fall Adora had taken in the woods. They had both been concussed over the years from training accidents. She knew the signs.

Adora was quick to grasp her hands and pull them away.

"Catra, I know I saw something out there. I just need to get another look,...it feels important somehow." Adora defended, her determined expression falling to one of deep contemplation and confusion.

"Sounds good, let's go!" Catra was all in, eager to get back out there and explore the woods some more. Anywhere was better than here, as long as she was with Adora everything would be alright.

'No, I do not want you to get into trouble on my behalf." Adora was adamant, offering Catra a consoling gesture of placing her hand on her shoulder. "Just cover for me…Ok. I will be back before anyone knows I'm gone. " She breathed a resolved sigh, suddenly darting off. Before, Catra could do or say anything else. Leaving Catra still half hidden behind the column calling Adora's name in frustration.

"How am I going to cover for you…Idiot." Catra grumbled, her ears pinned back against her head. Dawn had begun around her, while she brooded. The horizon beyond the fortress was burning, orange and blood red as if set on fire. The blaring toll of the morning alarm sounded into morning light. Waking the cadets in the barracks, to begin another day of training. Roll call would be happening in minutes. Then Adora's absence would be reported back to Shadow Weaver's…the dominos were falling…and it was up to Catra to play interference until Adora returned.

Catra groaned and rolled her eyes, "Cover for me, Catra…" She grumbled in a sarcastic sing-song. Groaning in exasperation, since their last stunt of taking off for over a week. The Red Squad

had been placed in lockdown within the Disciplinary Barracks for a month. Enduring long day's of reconditioning…without Adora. The blonde never spoke about her interrogation with Shadow Weaver or what she might have gone through herself in the absence of her entire Squadron. Their graduation had been canceled and they had been slowly earning back their privileges ever since. So their little escape last night with the skiff had been very dangerous. Not only for them, but for their entire squad as well. The fact that Adora would break the rules and steal a skiff and go for a joy ride just to cheer her up. Had been a really big deal, in mending some of the cracks in their friendship. Which were once again ripped open and widening now, that she had just taken off without her! On the pathetic pretext of not wanting to get her into trouble. When in reality, Catra was the one left to deal with the repercussions of Adora's selfish, impulsiveness yet again.

With a growl, Catra turned on her heel refusing to take the fall. If she was going to face punishment for Adora…yet again. Then she would stall the outcome for however long she could. Leaping from the railing, back onto the rear of the platform. She slowly climbed down the tower and skulked deeper into the Fright Zone. Intent on having a bit of fun, alluding to capture for the rest of the day. Which ended up being only a few hours later. A retrieval team sent to find her, were veterans at rounding up the magicat. Shadow Weaver was not messing around this time. They understood how Catra evaded when being chased and set up blockades, herding the magicat. Soldier's were already stationed to guard her usual hiding spots preventing her from going to ground. So after a good chase through several outlying sectors near the Forge. They had stunned her just outside the ore processing plant, dragging her back unconscious to the Black Garnet Chamber to face Shadow Weaver's interrogation.

Which oddly ended up being her first mission instead. Shadow Weaver knew exactly where Adora was, she had been tracking her. Obviously she was never going to lose her precious Adora again! Catra couldn't protect her this time. If she didn't bring her back she would suffer the consequences in Adora's stead. Enduring that vile woman's typical ominous intimidation tactics.

That always puts a stark terror into her very soul. Ingrained in her from childhood. So Catra was not driven to bring Adora back, at all cost.

As second in command of the Red Cadet Squadron, she was ordered to gather Strike Team Alpha and head to the infantry armory for a mission briefing. Where her, Lonnie, Kyle and Rogelio met up with at least a dozen other Strike Team's from various Senior Cadet Squads. This was their graduation…

Grizzlor would be leading the ground troops to Thaymor to seize the village and capture the rebel insurgence hiding out there. He had assigned Catra to the Tank units, since she had a pilot's license and a gunner's qualification. With a huge eager grin she reported to the Tank yard to join her field unit. Finally a chance to prove herself!

Adora

The previous day, settled in her mind, as they left Thaymor behind. Memories that are both euphoric and absolutely devastating. All falling, heavy upon her heart. A thick, all consuming sediment of so many conflicting emotions. That would take days, maybe months to wade through and sort out. She absently watched as the gray predawn faded away to the soft, morning light. As the warmth of a new day began to filter down through the branches of the trees cradling the sky overhead. Adora sat, lost in her thoughts on the back of the roan colored horse. That had been taken from Thaymor. Glimmer sat in front of her, slumped forward over the horse's thick neck fast asleep. The princess of Bright Moon had depleted all her magic in the battle. Between the crazy night they had evaded that monster and escaped the crumbling First Ones ruin and then narrowly survived the Horde. Glimmer had nothing left. Adora kept her unconscious

body steady, by holding her waist with one hand. She secured them on the horses back. By clutching the animal's loose ebony mane. The steady rocking of her body as the horse plodded, a repeating motion that comforted her. While haunted by two mismatched eyes, staring at her through the smoke. Full of hurt, betrayal and absolute horror at what she had become.

Thaymor was burning! Black smoke was billowing through the ruin's of demolished buildings. The heat at her back was intense, as the terrified cries of villages rent the air, followed by the harsh explosions of cannon blasts and the steady shouts of Horde, ground troops rounding up the survivor's.

"Look, there is no time, we have to put a stop to this." Adora pleaded. Her eye's frantically dart around the war torn village. Catching sight of Thaymorian's running through the smoke, in desperate fear to get away. Followed by squads of infantry soldier's advancing behind them, rifles drawn. With a contingent of Bots, clanking loudly, through the rubble along the periphery. Their long spider-like leg's swing over the ruins of homes. Herding the villager's…somewhere for capture.

"What…Why…" Catra scoffed, confused. Crossing her arms over her chest, and glaring at her indignantly.

"Because this is a civilian town!" Adora explained, her eyes pleading for Catra to show some compassion. To see how wrong this all was. "Look around, these are not insurgence! They are innocent people." She waved a hand ardently towards the chaos of an attack further down the street. As a tank fired repeatedly on a set of buildings, busting a hole right through. The colorful banner's from the festival, once stretched along the domed roofs. Now set a flame and flutter to the ground. Quickly rolled over by the treads of the tank as it continued demolishing the village.

"Sure, innocent people who kidnapped a Horde officer." Catra turned to regard her with a smirk, hand on her hip. As she

proclaimed her own understanding of the situation. The one she had received during her debrief before being sent to Thaymor with their strike team. "Now, come on. Let's get you back to the Fright Zone." She reached back and took Adora's hand. Leading her towards her tank. "Shadow Weaver is freaking out, it would be funny, if she wasn't such a terrible person." Catra laughed briefly at the old woman's expense, her amused expression melting away to resignation.

"Catra no! I can't go back. Not until the Horde leaves this town alone." Adora sharply pulled her hand out of Catra's grasp.

Catra was shocked, her ears twitching as she listened to Adora petition once again. Slowly turning back to her best friends with disbelief.

"You have to help me!" Adora pleaded.

Catra stood before her tank, taking a soft, calming breath. Adora was acting crazy and it was unsettling. What had happened to her? What had those two strangers…done to her?

"What are you saying?" Catra turned, in confusion.

"They have been lying to us. Manipulating us, Hordak, Shadow Weaver, all of them." Adora explained, her voice wavering with heartache at verbalizing those hard truths.

Catra merely blinked, completely dumbfounded by her best friend's obliviousness.

"Duh! Did you just figure that out!" Catra blurted out in frustration. "Manipulation is Shadow Weaver's whole thing. She has been messing with our heads since we were kids." Catra scowled bitterly, as she confronted Adora.

"How could you possibly be ok with that?" Adora frowned down at her, perplexed and saddened at how easily Catra just disregarded the abuse as if it meant nothing.

"Because it doesn't matter what they do." Catra placed her hands on Adora's shoulder's seeking to reconnect…like always. That, even though they didn't agree right now, they were a team and they had each other's backs. "The two of us look out for each other and soon we will be the ones calling the shots." She reminded her of their plan, that they were going to rise up the ranks and change how the Horde did things. That there was still hope to make Etheria better, as long as they stayed together. Her eyes were soft, pleading for Adora to understand…to stay.

To choose her…

Adora brows furrowed, as she stared down at her best friend. So many conflicting thoughts clashing inside her mind. Their plan wasn't going to work anymore. After finding the sword…accepting that strange woman's pledge to honor Grayskull and transforming into She-Ra. With everything she had seen, everything she had experienced…in the last few hours. She couldn't allow the Horde to get a hold of the incredible power she now possessed. She could never give Shadow Weaver any opportunity to control her again.

"Now come one, can we go home already." Catra figured that reminder was enough and they could get out there. Confident that Adora would come to her senses after their little talk. She turned and inclined a hand towards her tank, offering Adora to take the lead. She was a licensed pilot and could drive if she wanted to.

An explosion rocked through a nearby building. As a column of smoke and ash rose into the air and then billowed around them. Their shared moment to reconnect was broken and Adora came to her senses. She had crouched on instinct to remain below the smoke, so she could see any threats that may be headed towards them. Now she frowned up at Catra in disappointment.

"I'm not going home Catra…I can't not after everything I've seen.

"She rose back up, reaching for Catra's hand. "Come with me, you don't have to go back there. We can fix this. " She pleaded, blue

eyes wet with tears but full of hope. That Catra would follow her, as she always had. Trusting that Catra had meant what she said back at Scorpion Hills. That she would leave the Horde if offered something better. She was left stunned, when Catra's shocked expression twisted into anger instead. Yanking her hand out of Adora's grasp.

"Are you kidding…You've known these people for what! A couple of hours. Now you are going to throw everything away for them? " She ranted, arms waving in frustration. "Ughhh. What happened to you? She spat in disgust.

"I don't know…" Adora admitted softly. "But I have to do something. " Her desperate tears dried instantly, as her eyes hardened with determination. "I'm sorry, Catra." She turned away, striding forward with purpose. Resolved to her choice, with or without her best friend. She needed to do this, this was the only way to protect Etheria.

The sudden jolt of electricity against her back was alarming. As every muscle was set on fire and she collapsed to the ground, suddenly paralyzed.

"Oh ... .man…that was a-lot stronger than I thought." Catra gasped, staring down at her taser baton in shock. "Are you ok.." She questioned her fallen friend, her voice heavy with concern.

As Adora grunted and struggled against the ground, stubbornly fighting to regain the use of her limbs.

"Catra!" Adora spat back over her shoulder, indignant and angry. Only to have Catra, shove her live baton into her side in retaliation to her threatening tone. Adora screamed in agony. The electric shock, exploding over her body again was like living fire shooting across her whole body. Laying the blonde out for another time.

"Why…" Adora breathed, when she came back to her senses. Her whole body was on fire! Grimacing and shivering as every muscle

dealt with the trauma of enduring so many volts. "Why are you doing this?" She pleaded, her eyes wet with betrayal.

"Because you left me! " Catra responded, heatedly. "If I don't bring you back, Shadow Weaver will have my head." She pleaded for Adora to understand, to protect her from Shadow Weaver's wrath as she had always done.

"So enough with your weird little identity crisis and let's go home already!" Catra callously disregarded the upheaval of Adora's whole world that she had gone through in the last few hours. "Or do I need to zap you again?" She threatened, her voice wavering. Panic filled eyes wide and wet with frightened tears, desperate for Adora to choose her.

Adora took several steadying breaths, as she willed her paralyzed body to move. Adora was at Catra's mercy…one she was now worried Catra no longer possessed. As she had already tazed her twice. Then a blast of sparkles struck Catra in the face. She squealed in fright and ran away, never having been hit by magic before.

Adora raised her head, finding Bow and Glimmer coming to her rescue on horseback. Glimmer dismounted in front of her, as Bow reared the horse and veered away to prepare a volley to keep Catra at bay.

"Glimmer…" Adora groaned, in pain. As Glimmer crouched down and helped her to stand.

Bow notched an arrow and fired at Catra. It struck her in the chest, a net unfurling and binding her arms tight to her sides. Catra went down, rolling, hissing and crying in frustration and rising fear. She was going to lose Adora!

She couldn't lose her…she couldn't lose her…she couldn't lose her…

Adora glanced over her shoulder, taking a shuddering breath. At the predatory glare, Catra was sending Bow and Glimmer. The raw

hatred, burning in her mismatched eyes, was devoid of any compassion. They had become her prey…

Catra's thumb swiftly reset the charge on the handle of her baton. Sending a laser blast towards Glimmer and Adora.

Bow shouted in warning, as Glimmer teleported them away. The last thing she heard was Catra screaming her name in absolute terror.

Adora stared down at her hands, clutching the dark mane of the horse. Her hands were trembling. Heartbroken and frightened, she valiantly kept her emotion's hidden. She felt so alone…now. She had lost her home, her best friend…everything? Her whole life had been a lie, used and manipulated by adults who she had trusted? The most shocking and terrifying aspect of the last day was that she was a Princess! What the hell did she do with that! She had become something she had been raised to hate! She had no idea how to transform or use her powers. Her whole existence was upside down and inside out…sideways…even…Adora was screaming silently on the inside, for all that she had to give up and the endless unknowns that lay ahead.

S1E3:Razz

Catra

The locker room was tense. The survivor's of their attack on Thaymor, having just limped home on a couple busted tanks. Suffering ridicule from other squads, and rank file soldier's alike at getting their collective ass kicked by a one princess. As they walked in shame down the corridors of the barracks. The reports

of how absolutely overpowered that Princess was and how she had decimated their war machines. Making a mockery of them. Catra was further stressed by the growing dread of eventually having to report to Shadow Weaver. Knowing that to avoid worse punishment and not incite Shadow Weaver's spiteful temper. She would have to meekly put up with the vile woman's harsh assessments of how she botched the mission. She would take all the blame. Allow that bitter crone to squash her pride and self worth even more. As she recounted what had happened in spiteful detail and why she was such a disappointment, how worthless and incompetent she was at not being able to retrieve Adora.

All in all it had been a truly horrific day! Which was pretty on brand, for most of Catra's days in the Horde.

Now Catra was crouched on a sewage pipe in the shadows of the locker room. Silently enduring Lonnie's exaggerated recounting of events. Aloof and brooding, she listened absently while cleaning her fur with her tongue. Seeking to soothe her heartache and quell the fear growing in her guts. At having to face the consequences of her failure.

" *I'm telling you, this new princess is no joke. She wiped the floor with our whole recon squad!" Lonnie explained to Levi and Max. Waving her arms frantically as she told her tale. Standing in front of her locker, while Rogelio wrapped a bandage around a wound on Kyle's arm.*

Kyle was still shell shocked from his close encounter with that Princess. His thoughts in turmoil, on constant replay on the battle he narrowly survived. That had been his first taste of being on the front line of the war…and it had rocked him to his very core. He had come to many realizations, about who he truly was, what his priorities were and who he could count on most when shit went down.

They had the rebel archer pinned down just on the outskirts of Thaymor. Then that super powered Princess appeared in a halo of golden light. Her eyes glowing a fearsome electric blue. She had strided purposefully into their midst, completely unfazed by the overwhelming firepower now trained upon her. She paid the Pincer tanks and ground troops surrounding her a hard, unforgiving glare. Then thrust her sword into the ground. A massive wave of magic erupted from the blade. As the earth rumbled and heaved under her power, the tanks were thrown aside as if they were mere toys. The soldier's standing nearby screamed in terror as the ground sought to swallow them whole. The concussive force of her magic sends a skiff sideways, knocking the troops to the ground. A tank on the ridge of the ravine just above the demolished buildings of the battlefield. Pointed their laser cannon right at her. But she merely pulled her sword out of the ground and charged. Her speed was incredible, leaping into the very sky itself, as she came down like a meteor, slicing the cannon in half with her sword. Leaping away just as the tank exploded. That fearsome Princess had landed just before Kyle. As he had been a part of the ground troops surrounding the rebel archer. He had been brave, as he charged with his baton without thinking. His military training took over, in the instant he was in combat. Striking at her with his baton, only to have it deflected by her sword. As she parried. The sudden, sharp pain that had exploded up his arm had been agonizing when their weapon collided. He had crumpled at her feet, but she never finished him off. Thankfully, quickly distracted by a bot that had taken its chance to strike while she was distracted. She had turned, leaping up onto the ridge and grabbing the bot by its leg and swinging it away into the opposing wall of the ravine. It had exploded upon impact. The heat slammed into him first, then the wall of flames and billowing smoke overtook his position. Someone had called a retreat and Kyle was more than happy to obey. He had fled to find cover, cradling his arm. That he believed was broken at the time. Rogelio had found him behind the rubble of a building in the aftermath of the battle. Ripping off his helmet and snarling and growling at him. Admonishing him for recklessly confronting a Princess. The Lizard had him take off his chest

armor and triaged the arm. Thankfully, the shock absorption of the armor's insulation had reduced the damage to just a sprained wrist.

"Twelve feet tall at least! She took out every one of our machines, with nothing but a sword." Lonnie pretended to swing an imaginary sword. While Max, leaning against the locker's nearby, stared at her in disbelief. Levi stood on otherside of the benches, arms crossed. As she silently listened to Lonnie.

"Did you actually see her?" Levi asked, as Lonnie's tale seemed a little far fetched from the intel they had been taught about the Princess's power levels.

"No, it's a good thing too. We were lucky to get out of there alive." Lonnie admitted.

"Oh, please." Catra rolled her eyes and finally had enough of Lonnie's embellishment of the facts and needed to set the record straight. "She's just like every other princess." She hopped off the pipe, a smug smile on her face. "All sparkle and no substance. She caught us off guard. That is all." Catra stated, completely discrediting the severity of Lonnie's account of events.

Rogelio was unimpressed, with Catra's bravado. He had witnessed that Princess, albeit from a safe distance upon the ridge with the bots. She was a hell of a lot more than sparkles! Kyle stared at her with a pained look. He had actually engaged with her, narrowly escaping thanks to the cover provided by that destroyed bot. Had the sprained wrist to account for it.

"Sure…you were the only one who saw her up close." Lonnie scoffed. "And you didn't even land a hit on her." Lonnie crossed her arms, "What did you freeze up!" She taunted.

Catra launched herself from in front of the benches, her temper flaring. Getting right up into Lonnie's face, fist clenched in warning beneath the dark skinned woman's chin. "You think I'm scared of

some princess. I could take her out whenever I want. I know her secret." She hissed.

"Oh, yeah!" Lonnie shoved her away. Catra grunted, piercing Lonnie with a threatening glare. Silently, telling her that if Lonnie wanted a fight, she would end it real quick. "And what's that?' Lonnie responded mockingly, ready to engage. As Catra snarled ready to attack.

When both Levi and Max closed on either side of Lonnie, ready to defend her if Catra tried to slash at her. Catra quickly accessed her chances of winning, glancing from Levi to Max. Who were standing in solidarity with Lonnie. Bodies tense and poised to defend. Lonnie stood between them, arms crossed, staring her down. Her hazel eyes held no threat, just irritation. She didn't want to fight, she just wanted Catra to stop acting all unscathed. That battle had been brutal and they were all lucky to be alive. Why couldn't she just admit that they had been out matched, be part of the team for once instead of acting like a big shot!

"Like I'd tell you." Catra shot back venomously.

"Easy, Catra. Adora ain't here to protect you anymore." Lonnie reminds her coldly. Catra never made friend's only enemies, if she wasn't careful now she would be dead within the year if not sooner.

Catra's chest clenched and her stomach dropped in fear once more. She slowly bowed her head and retreated out of the locker room. Adora had abandoned her, breaking her promise. She was alone now….it hit like a cannon blast to the chest.

Lost to the turbulence of her thoughts. She found herself unconsciously back at the bunkroom. Crossing her arms and glaring bitterly as she entered, the door's retracting behind her in quiet hiss. As she prowled back to Adora's bunk, flopping down upon the hard mattress. Depleted in every way, she had unconsciously sought the comfort of the blonde's scent. As she always did after a long, hard day. Yet this time, her scent burned

like acid against her nose. Their etching that they had carved late one night as junior cadet's caught her eye. She turned, regarding the images of her and Adora with scorn. Laying back upon Adora's bed, her chest heaving with pent up emotions. As her disappointment and anger compounded inside of her. Her grief and heartbreak pounding against her emotional control.

They had been in their fourth year of junior cadet training. Trapped inside the bunkroom during a torrential rain storm. The memory once fond, now curdled inside her heart. Soured by how her whole world had crumbled away at Thaymor.

A sharp scraping sound, vibrated out from Adora's lower bunk. Followed by embarrassed giggles and raspy laughter.

"I look so dumb…" Adora cackled, watching Catra finish the etching of her face with her index claw, on the side of her bunk. Catra's face had been drawn first and looked cooler, with her wild mane and sharp teeth. Adora's face was goofy looking compared to her's. She figured Catra had done it on purpose.

"Yeah, well you do have a dumb face!" Catra agreed teasingly, she had her tongue sticking out in concentration as she finished scratching the last few details of Adora's hair poof.

'You have a dumb face!" Adora declared, retaliating by pushing Catra down on her mattress. Digging her finger into her armpits, tickling the soft part savagely.

Catra squealed and writhed under her best friend, who now had her at her mercy.

Straddling her narrow waist and pinning her down on the mattress. In time Catra's innocence etching would change slightly, as she scratched her mask in place as a teenager.

She lost control…

In a fit of white hot rage, Catra surged up and slashed Adora's face. Destroying the once happy looking etching. The violent action unleashed the torrent of emotions and pain that Catra had been keeping contained since Thaymor. Overwhelmed by her misery, drowning inside her anger as her heart finally shattered. She released the fury of that storm of emotions upon Adora's bunk. Raising her chin towards the sky, a broken scream ripped from her lungs, followed by hot tears, streaming down her face. She began to slash at Adora's mattress with her claws. Lost to the satisfaction of tearing her bed apart, punching her pillow until it was flat. Sharp teeth gnashing and tail lashing, her hot tears rolling down her face as she knelt upon the mattress and shredded it right down to the metal floor. The tiny fractures upon her fragile, glass heart, that Adora had inflicted as they grew up… had weakened her ability to withstand this final rejection. This time after Thaymor… her betrayal of their promise had shattered her completely. The agony of having your hopes and dreams obliterated, in a single moment. It was more than she could handle. Adora was gone and she wasn't coming back! She didn't care what happened to her…she didn't want her, she didn't matter enough to stay…she cared more about that sparkly princess and the Arrowboy…it hurt….it hurt so bad…Catra couldn't breathe, couldn't comprehend how Adora could just leave her after everything they had went through together? Her thoughts were consumed in a negative spiral of bitterness…and despair…she felt so worthless…

Why….why wasn't she good enough….

Her fit of rage and sorrow was quickly snuffed out, when Shadow Weaver shouted her name. Catra jumped in sudden fright, slamming her head against the top bunk. It was time to face the consequences of her failure. Catra scrambled out of the bunk and stood at attention, as her conditioning as a soldier took control. But the residual ire that was still coursing through her veins, twisted her attitude. She crossed her arms and cocked her hip irritated by Shadow Weaver's unwanted presence.

“Impertinent as always, I see.” Shadow Weaver sniped. “With such a grand failure under your belt.” She continued, reaching out, brushing her fingertips down Catra’s cheek. Catra's eyes followed her touch, wary and uncertain. As the crone's fingers swept to her chin and roughly clutched the point and pulled her head forward roughly. “Cadet.” She spat in disappointment.

“I did exactly what you told me to do. “ Catra jerked away from her touch. “You were the one that did not warn us that there would be Princesses there.” She pointed, accusing Shadow Weaver of being a negligent superior officer. Twisting the truth to her own advantage, how the hell was Shadow Weaver going to know Adora was a Princess ... .When she had sent them out.

Catra would keep that secret…she had no intention of telling Shadow Weaver anything.

“I gave you a simple task, bring back Adora!” Shadow Weaver rose up on her shadow’s to loom over Catra. Steepling her fingers before her as she scowled down at her. “Instead your squadrons were ravaged, war machines destroyed and Adora is still missing!” She continued to rant, her shadow curling ominous around Catra.

The magicat kept a keen eye on them, all while glaring indignantly up at the Sorceress. “New’s flash, old lady. If Adora wanted to come home, she’d be here right now. Adora’s gone, she defected and I am starting to think she had the right idea! So maybe it's you who should be showing a little more respect to me!” Catra was so furious, she was the one who stayed! She was the loyal daughter! And still this miserable, ungrateful woman refused to acknowledge that she was the better daughter. She was so sick and taking the blame for Adora!

“Lies!” Shadow Weaver was livid. She rose even high, to the very roof of the bunkroom, her shadow’s lashing out and shattered all of the bunkroom's lights. Casting the entire room into darkness. “I have not the patience to address your incompetence, or your insubordination. Cadet!”

Catra barely held her fear in check, heart beating fast against her ribs as all she could see. Now that the room was completely black was Shadow Weaver's menacingly glowing white eyes inside her insidiously vile blood red, metal mask. Unconsciously, Catra started to back up only to have the shadow's curl behind her caging her in. A fear so primal, so all consuming came to life. Rising from the very core of her. As the conditioning from her cruel upbringing at the hands of this power hungry woman took over. All sense of self agency quickly left her. She froze, cowering in terror. She would willingly obey…Shadow Weaver had taken control.

"You will answer to the higher power. Lord Hordak…himself." Shadow Weaver's threatening aura completely engulfed her. As the sorceress clutched Catra's arm in an iron grip and dragged her out of the bunkroom.

Adora

It had been a long and exhausting day. Morning had been stressful…being hidden in Glimmer's room. Commanded to become She-Ra, so Queen Angella would accept her. Making a dumb choice to go outside and practice summoning She-Ra, even after Bow warned her about the pitchforks and torches. Accidentally, changing Horsey into an Alicorn had been startling and rather frightening. She had essentially become her own worst nightmare. A Princess with incredible power that she did not know how to use! She had become a danger to everyone! Getting chased into the Whispering Woods…by the refugee's camped outside of Bright Moon. Was upsetting, she wasn't used to being feared and hated on sight. Then getting lost in the Whispering Woods and finding a crazy old lady. Who was strangely wise and seemed to know about She-Ra. At least about her sword and a

woman named Mara. It had been the first bit of good luck she had all day. She ended up following that old woman, desperate for answers and direction as to what she should do. The woman had led her to a Horde outpost. The devastated acres of woods were horrible to see, they were destroying the land just like they had done around the Fright Zone. The soldier's were clear cutting the trees and had captured Horsey. Determined to stop them from harming her friend, she had managed to turn into She-Ra and destroy the base. Sending Force Captain Grizzlor back to the Fright zone with his surviving men. Horsey…which she found out from Madame Razz thought that was a stupid name and wanted to be called Swift Wind. Had given her a ride back to the castle.

Now she stood before the long, narrow bridge that spanned the lake. Hiding just out view within the treeline. Dusk was falling over the valley, the somber half light made the floating stone atop the slender golden spire before the castle. Shine like a brilliant silver lantern upon the backdrop of the coming night. The elegant white spires of the central keep of Bright Moon Castle stood out from the rocky crags of Sky Dancer Mountain. The sheer size and majesty of the main keep and the many lower, domed bastion's of towers was breathtaking. As the Greater Moon's were ascending over the mountain's peak. Adora was frozen half hidden behind a tree, staring in wonder and trepidation about leaving cover. Her thoughts replaying her last few hours with Razz. Trying to find her answers about how to move forward.

"I need you to tell me what to do!" Adora called desperately, as Razz quickly shuffled out view through the trees.

"How would Madame Razz know what you should do?" The old lady laughed with amusement.

"Look I left my whole life behind, looking for answers about where I came from and who I am supposed to be." Adora groaned, between finding the sword, what the creepy vision lady had shown her and made her vow. To fight for the honor of

Grayskull…whatever the hell that was? Then seeing the weird She-Ra mural inside that First Ones Beacon. Urghhh…she was so confused and scared...desperate for any kind of guidance. "The Rebellion hates me and I can't go back to the Horde." Adora sighed, peering down at her sword. That had been nothing but trouble all day. "I want to do the right thing…but I don't know what that is." She finished with an exasperated groan.

The utter destruction of the forest had been heartbreaking so see. After crossing through its beautiful groves the previous night. The trio had been sheltered under the forest's protective embrace, as the woods led them gently back to Bright Moon. They had been exhausted in both body and spirit and the woods sensed that and took care of them. Adora was coming to understand that so much of what she had been taught in the Horde was wrong.

"Ah, It's the same old story, dearie. Wicked people destroy what they can not control. " Razz sighed, heavily. A knowing sadness in her eyes.

"They can't just do this!" Adora responded, her voice cracking in sorrow and anger. As she surveyed the devastation.

"Once the Princesses would have protected us, but these days they stay in their castles, protecting only their own lands. Meanwhile the Horde creeps ever closer." Razz hummed, "You are very much like my Mara, you know. Brave, loyal, but afraid."

"I'm not afraid." Adora had defended, refusing to admit how she truly felt.

"Dearie, you ran into the woods and asked the first old lady you could find, What you should do." Razz giggled sagely, shaking her head. " No one is going to make this easy for you, dearie. Stop, waiting for someone to tell you what the right thing to do is… you're a smart girl…what do you think!" Razz admonished her, with a kind smile.

"I think this is wrong…" Adora had responded, her voice strong and full of conviction. As she stared out at the clear cut grove, surrounded by Horde machines.

Adora narrowed her eyes and with a firm nod, she walked out of cover and strode with purpose across the bridge. She wasn't a soldier for the Horde anymore, no one was going to tell her how to think, or what to do. She was making her own choices now, right or wrong they were her's. She would do whatever she needed to, to be accepted by the Queen of Bright Moon. She had barely mounted the steps up to the front doors of the outer ramparts. Before the two guards stationed at the top of the stairs, shouted and charged at her with spears, drawn. She raised her hands in submission and allowed the guards to take her into custody. She was quickly subdued by the guards and escorted before the Queen. Where she had quickly knelt and presented the Sword of Protection. Pledging She-Ra to Queen Angella and promising to free Etheria from the Horde. Now, Glimmer had just led her out of the throne room. Adora was walking behind, head constantly on a swivel as she took in Bright Moon in all its glory. Her eyes widened with wonder at how beautiful and full of light it was. With the cavernous hallways and high arching windows inlaid with intricate gold trim. For the first time, she had chosen a course forward in her life for herself. She had to make this work out. The rebellion may not trust Adora, but they trusted She-Ra she could work with that. Perhaps in time, the people of Etheria would come to trust Adora as well. But she had to prove herself first.

She could do that…

S1E4:Flower's for She-Ra

Adora

Night was falling over the lush valley where Bright Moon Castle was nestled. The Greater Moon's had taken to the sky above the Whispering Woods. While Adora had been pledging She-Ra's aid to Queen Angella in the throne room. Glimmer had taken her on a brief tour of the Castle, eventually ending up at her room. That had promptly overwhelmed her with its sheer size and opulence.

What the hell was she supposed to do with a Waterfall!

Glimmer had left, wanting to get ready for bed herself. Letting her know if she needed anything, her room was just up the hallway.

Now Adora had settled upon the plush window seat in her room. Her sword was laying on the far end of the seat. Far enough away to be ignored but still within arm's reach if needed. She had also discarded her belts and red jacket somewhere. Now only in stocking feet, her white long sleeve shirt and gray pants. Huddled up against the rounded corner of the window pane, leaning her forehead against the cool glass. Her expression was a pensive frown, her blue eyes weary and dull. Sluggishly she adjusted herself more securely into the corner. Tucking her knee's partially up into the wide golden window frame. Holding her legs in a tight embrace against her chest. Staring mournfully out into the darkness, watching absently how water of Half Moon lake seemed to be sparkling in the moonlight. So lost in the weary round of her thoughts, she never really took in the serenity that surrounded the castle. It had been a long, very long and hard day.

Her room was near Glimmer's in one of the lower tower's in the outer bastion of the Castle. She was still high enough that she could survey most of the lower courtyards and outer most ramparts. Her training unconsciously took over, as surveyed the guards' routes along the walls. Slowly drawing her sight upward back to the dark sky. The moon's were just cresting the tree's on the edge of the lake, a shimmering aura of magic dancing like a

halo just above the forest. The magic of this place was breathtaking. But Adora ignored all of the beauty that now surrounded her. Focused on her inner turmoil she could not appreciate it. Her brow was furrowed into a troubled frown. Her blue eyes were distant, staring into nothing but the past. As she valiantly tried to sort out her thoughts and try to make plans for the future.

The last two day's had been an absolute whirlwind. She had found a magical sword, became a princess, defected from the Horde….lost her best friend. Adora took a slow, shuddering breath as a single tear fell from the corner of her eye. She ignored the moisture against the hot skin of her cheek, hugging her knees tighter and resting her chin upon them. Continuing to ponder how their interaction had gone so very wrong and how she could possibly fix things. She just needed to talk to Catra again, make her understand why she left? She must not have explained her reasoning very well. So when she ran into her again, she would try and make her understand. Catra was just angry and not thinking rationally. That was all.

She would come around eventually.

Adora sighed, watching the changing of the guards out on the lower ramparts near the edge of the lake. Bright Moon was so strange, with its pristine stone walls and wide elegant hallways and tall multi faceted, rainbow tinted windows. Yet its military was so similar to that of the Horde. They all wore matching armor, had rigorous training and patrolled the castle grounds. In very the same militaristic fashion as the Horde Soldier's did. The strict sense of hierarchy, of discipline and predictable routine to their days was unmistakable. Her mind wandered along that avenue for a time, reviewing all that she had learned about the world outside of the Fright Zone.

That it wasn't all that scary or deadly as what she had been taught. Princesses were not violent instigators who couldn't control their powers and were a scourge upon the unprotect civilians of Etheria. It was quite the opposite. It was the Horde

that was terrorizing the citizens in their war to subjugate them all under their rule.

Now she chose to ally herself to the Alliance. Vowing to free Etheria from the Horde and bring about a lasting peace.

Which was a rather daunting task right now, since she had no idea how to control her magic and transforming into She-Ra was kinda a hit or miss.

It was late into the night, when Adora finally uncurled from the window seat and attempted to sleep in the overstuffed, round bed full of pillows that occupied her giant room.

The rest of the night…was on par for how her last few days had been going. Chaotic and scary, full of uncertainty and self doubt. She killed the bed, ran into the Queen and came to the realization that the woman really did not care for her…like at all. She pretty much told her that since Glimmer vouch for her, she would give her a chance to prove herself. The only reason she was allowed to stay was because she was She-Ra. But even that was met with a wariness, the Queen's trust had to be earned. Adora understood that, she could work with that.

She ended up wandering around the castle for hours, getting lost repeatedly and having to ask a guard to lead her back up to wing off the castle her bedroom was on. It was just before dawn, when she finally stumbled into Glimmer's room. Nervous, but desperate for rest. She climbed the floating stairs up to the Princess's bed and curled up into a pathetic ball at her feet. Sniffling but too exhausted to cry. She finally fell asleep.

Catra

A week had passed without Adora…Hordak had promoted Catra to Force Captain in Adora's place. She had moved out of the bunkroom and into her own private Quarters in the command barracks near the Forge.

She had power…she had a safe place to lock herself away when she slept or needed time to take a breath. The possibilities of earning higher rank and privilege was finally within her grasp. She could work with that…

She just had to earn respect or teach the other Force Captain's to fear her? She could climb up the ranks…she could change the Horde…she could take over…all by herself? It was overwhelming, it was invigorating…it felt lonely…it felt hollow.

She could ignore that…

So she found herself once more, retreating high up on the platform sanctuary. That overlooked the macabre looking towers of the Forge. She had spent many evenings here hiding out with Adora. Dreaming and conspiring about their future together. Now she sat alone, sitting at the very edge of the open deck, outside the safety of the railing. She held her new Force Captain's badge lightly between her fingers, resting her hands in her lap. As her bare feet dangled over the edge. Wallowing in her bitterness as her mind spiraled down dark and spiteful paths. Glaring with loathing, at the angry red twilight that batted the horizon. As doubts about her own abilities to achieve their dream on her own began to surface.

Shadow Weaver had found her in the Holo simulator, where Red Alpha was training against a bot. Gloating to Lonnie and the boys about her promotion to Force Captain. The Sorceress was quick to assert her dominance over her. Looming over her like a menacing shadow. Instantly, Catra had turned, chirped a grin and flashed

her a quick salute. When the old woman silently pointed towards the locker's, she hung her head and meekly followed. Silently, fortifying herself tor the woman's wrath.

"What do you need Shadow Weaver?" Catra groused, as she stood in front of the locker's. Valiantly trying to resurrect her bravado that had been so ravaged by the horrible woman during their last encounter in the bunkroom. Hating how submissive and weak she had just looked towards her teammates just seconds ago. Following after the Sorceress with her head down, like a chastised little kid.

Shadow Weaver had her back to her, arms folded and brooding.

"Oh…are you giving me my first mission?" Catra perked up, eyes widening in hope.

"You will explain how you lost Force Captain Adora!" Shadow Weaver spun back, the runestone shard flaring with power.

Catra instantly went on high alert. Standing at attention, cringing in fear…knowing how volatile she safely was at this moment. Then her rage took over, unwilling to act like a coward again. It fortified her in the ways she needed to assert herself. She released an insufferable groan, pressing her hands to her face. "I told you everything I know about Adora!" She ranted, balling her hands into fists and then pounding Adora's old locker. As Shadow Weaver hovered past her. Catra was shocked, for a second. Noticing that the locker now sported a stupid picture of the new princess on her flying horse! Catra promptly glanced at Shadow Weaver, wondering if the old crone had noticed. That picture would only infuriate Shadow Weaver more and that would be bad for Catra. She swiftly ripped off the drawing and balled it up in fury. Because honestly, it pissed her off too.

"What happened to Adora!" Shadow Weaver returned, to loom over Catra. Her ominous shadow curled over the now wary magicat. "What did you do!" The sorceress accused in a low growl, backing Catra up against the locker's. The static hum of her

magic began to grow all around her. Catra's ears fell and she stared up into the Sorceress's face, barely concealing terror. Confronted by that faceless mask and white glowing eyes off her worst nightmares. Struggling as always when Shadow Weaver threatened her to remain strong and not tremble. In the end she retaliated, as she always had. Fueled by her bitterness and resentments towards Adora. Needing to defend herself before her Superior Officer's biased accusations. Desperate for Shadow Weaver to see her for once! To acknowledge that she was worth something…

"What did I do!" Catra surged forward into Shadow Weaver's personal space, forcing the old woman to hover backward. Glaring at the sorceress with hurt in her mismatched eyes. "She left us, she left me.You ever think Adora isn't as loyal as you thought?" Catra shouted in desperation, seeking to advocate that she was the better daughter. She had stayed! She was obeying!

"I will learn the truth Catra…" Shadow Weaver surged forward, power shard gleaming more brightly as she charged her magic. Her blood red robe flutters violently and curls like a spider's web around Catra. " Even if I have to drag it from yo…" She snarled, as the magicat swallowed hard, cringing in fear and backing up into the locker's. Squeezing her eyes shut, to await the inevitable searing pain of Shadow Weaver's dark magic. Then the old woman groaned and lurched backward. Grasping her mask in pain, as the shard blinked out.

Catra was worried? What happened? Catra sought to reach out and comfort the old woman. Who was in so much pain…pain that Catra understood. But just as she moved to touch her, Shadow Weaver pushed her away and swiftly retreated from the room.

The memory bites hard, poisoning her self confidence. Now she was wondering why the hell she was still here? Why didn't she go with Adora? She hated this place! She hated Shadow Weaver! She

hated how even though she had a bit of power now, as a Force Captain. That evil witch still scared the shit out of her.

She had kept silent during her interrogation after Adora had left, then after Thaymor, about Adora's defection to the Rebellion. She had kept the secret that Adora was She-Ra. A secret that could have dire consequences for her. Adora had broken her heart, but she still cared about her. She still protected her! She didn't want Shadow Weaver to get her dark magic tendrils back into her former best friend. She would hurt her, kill her even to get that magic for herself. But in the end that stupid blonde couldn't just lay low for long. The arrogant, self righteous 'hero' that she was, couldn't back down from a fight. She had to attack a Horde outpost in the Whispering Woods. Obviously the outpost's surveillance cameras sent an infiltration report back to Central Command. Now Shadow Weaver had her suspicions about what had happened to her…but no real proof.

(Force Captain Catra, report to Commander Shadow Weaver immediately at the Black Garnet chamber) Her badge flashed in her hands, as the order came through.

"What now?" Catra tapped the badge, snapping her petulant answer at the faceless operator who had summoned her. Refusing to budge from her preferred brooding spot.

(There has been a sighting of She-Ra in Plumeria. You are to assemble a strike team and investigate the destruction of a Horde camp near the border.)

"Fine, I'm on my way to the Black Garnet Chamber, prepare a skiff. I'll be there with Red Alpha, in a half hour." She snarled, slapping the badge back above her right breast.

Catra stormed out of the Black Garnet chamber. Shadow Weaver knew Adora's secret now! Her whole body was tense and vibrating with anxiety, rage and shame. As soon as Shadow Weaver had

threatened her with dark magic she had caved, Her cowardly self had just pledged to bring Adora in…going against Hordak's order's to just forget her.

"Fuck!" Catra screamed to the sky. She didn't know what to do anymore. She wanted to hate Adora, it would be so much easier to do Shadow Weaver's bidding if she didn't care what happened to her. Adora would end up back in Shadow Weaver's clutches, it was inevitable at this point.

Growling and snarling through the corridor's back to the training sector. Resigning herself to the outcome that lay ahead for Adora.

Time to go roundup Lonnie and the boys.

Dammit Adora!

Part Two

Chapter Notes

> Thank you PinkStorm for your comment and all who have left Kudos. The chapter count may have to change, Princess Prom and Promise could be a chapter onto themselves. Lol.

S1E5: The Sea Gate

Adora

Everything hurt…

Fixing the Sea Gate had taken everything she had. Now she was lying prone on the deck of Sea Hawks new boat. The Dragon's Daughter four…maybe five.

Urghhh…her brain felt like mush. Would transforming into She-Ra ever get easier? Her silent lament to the magic woman she had seen in the strange vision, when she first touched the sword went unanswered.

As always…

She had gone into the woods many times in the last few weeks, attempting to find that beacon. With the She-Ra mosaic, that she had sought refuge in on that fateful night with Bow and Glimmer. But the woods always shifted as she wandered, leading her right back to Bright Moon instead.

As always…

The softer hues of twilight were bathing the sky, as the Day Moon set far in the distance. As the sloop passed through the Sea Gate

and back into open water, heading north once more to Sea Worthy. It was still rather hot, the heat of the day seemed to have seeped into the decking. The polished wood beneath her was still warm, it was soothing for her tight muscles but also made her feel clammy. The sea air was humid and the salt water was slick upon her exposed skin. Which wasn't much more than just her face and hands. Since she refused to wear anything, but her red jacket, long sleeve shirt and gray pants. So the heavier cloth was soaked with sweat and clinging to her in all the worst ways. She was uncomfortable, sore and frustrated. Staring blankly up at the somber pastel palette of the sky, barely able to move her eyeballs. Watching the feathering blanket of clouds, migrating across her field of view. She groaned, as a shadow fell over her, blocking out the expanse of sky above her.

"You ok, there Adora." Bow stared down at her, crouched at her side. His gentle brown eyes, full of concern.

"Just peachy…" Adora grunted, with a tight smile. Deflecting his concern with sarcasm. The relief and celebration of winning their battle with Horde and gaining another Princess to the Alliance. Had evaporated quickly, as the Sloop departed the Salineas bay, heading back home…er…Bright Moon. Adora had to be honest, it wasn't home.

"She-Ra takes a-lot out of you, huh?' He settled down on the deck beside her. Crossing his legs and setting his quiver down beside himself. So he could rummage through his remaining arrow's, pulling out ones that needed mending. Noting with a grunt, that after their last battle, he was down a few trick arrows and would need to restock.

"That's an understatement, Bow. But I can handle it. I just gotta train harder. " Adora rolled her head to the side, offering him a small encouraging smile. Bow smiled back, his eyes gleaming with excitement. "I'll be right beside you, then. Training buddy." He raised a fist and offered it to Adora.

Adora chuckled, groaning in pain as she attempted to move her arm. All her effort earned her a limp twitch of a finger.

“Opps…sorry…” Bow offered, with a sympathetic grimace.

Adora merely sighed wearily and closed her eyes. She just needed some time to decompress…her first encounter with Catra in weeks. Had been a total and absolute nightmare!

With the chaos of the sea battle raging below her. Adora valiantly stayed focused on her task. Channeling all her magic through the sword and into the glowing barrier of glyphs. That made up the Salineas Sea Gate.

She had only been She-Ra for a few weeks, figuring out how to transform had been trial and error. But now she had that part down pat, it was maintaining her magical persona for extended periods of time that was the current dilemma. This was the first time she ever tried channeling that magic through her sword as well. It took a lot out of her, both physically and mentally. Right now, it was taking everything she had, to stand here on this floating platform of stone and hold the sword up.

She was still reeling from the painful energy discharge the Gate had redirected through her sword. From the Horde Warship's last cannon volley into it. The blasts were too strong, overloading the magical barrier. The Sea Gate could only absorb so much. The excess charge was siphoned through the connection to the sword and unfortunately right into She-ra's body.

The Hordes relentless assault was blowing more holes into the barrier than she was able to seal. Her whole body was trembling, as the energy crackled up her arms and across her chest. As she desperately sought to fix the broken glyphs. Panting and groaning in pain, she squeezed her eyes shut. She had never tried to repair First One's tech before, but after translating the First Ones glyphs etched onto the chiton shell walls of the throne room of

Mermista's Castle. She had felt confident that she knew how to fix it.

As long as she wasn't distracted…she could do this!

A sudden slight weight bent the sword blade downward, along with the condescending cackle she knew all too well. Adora snapped her eyes open to find Catra perched just before the cross guard. Glaring inches away from her face, with disgust.

"The tiara looks stupider the more I look at it." She commented venomously.

"Catra, how did you find me?" Adora managed to gasp out, then cried out in pain as another discharge rocketed through her. Causing her to lose focus and the energy from her sword faded away.

"Did you think it would be that easy to escape the Horde." Catra smirked. "I always knew you were kinda dumb, but com'on." She pressed the tip of her claw into Adoras forehead. A silent taunt Catra had used since hand to hand combat in their youth, to mock her and let her know she had the advantage.

That she was winning.

"What's your plan, insult me till I decide to rejoin the Horde?" Adora snapped back, gruffly. Her arms were on fire! With Catra's added weight she was struggling to hold the blade level and continue fixing the gate. Refusing to look weak, she grimaced instead. Widened her stand to compensate for the added weight and stubbornly locked her elbows to keep the Sword level. Reigniting the magic and shooting it back through the sword tip at the center glyph in the gate.

The magic was absorbed and then channeled outward through the various glyphs back into the power stone's. Held in the stone sentry statues on either side of the gate.

"I don't think Shadow Weaver is planning on giving you much of a choice." Catra responded, with a sly smile. "But yeah, something like that!" the magicat reared back, swinging the arm she once had extended to poke Adora in the forehead behind herself. Unsheathing her claws fully and then striking with lightning speed.

She-Ra just barely managed to block her attack with her gold bracer. As Catra leaped behind her, just as another discharge from the barrier washed over her body. Adora cried out, her body starting to buckle under the crackling energy coursing over her. Gritting her teeth, she clasped the hilt with both hands once more, refusing to give in.

"Check it out! With you gone, I got your promotion." Catra strutted in front of her, tapping her Force Captain badge proudly.

"Congratulations.." Adora scoffed, it was taking everything just to maintain her stance. Her whole body felt electrified, her legs felt numb and her arms were burning as if they had been set on fire! She had no time or patience to deal with Catra's smug attitude.

Catra was startled for all of a second. Then she frowned with disappointment at Adora's snide reaction. Her attempt to incite jealousy…as a means to get Adora to return and reclaim her title. Instantly shut down, like the Force Captain badge didn't matter…it stung…and Catra had no idea who this person was anymore?

"It seemed like only yesterday, this was the thing you wanted most in the world…and now your ugghhh." She circled She-Ra, coming back to her front and waving a hand up and down, revolted. "Com'on Adora. Hasn't this gone on long enough?" Catra's voice softened, her heart felt petition striking Adora hard. She-Ra's glow left her eyes, as she finally turned her gaze from the gate to look down at her best friend. When her gentle voice did not match the

gloating smirk she wore. Adora's eyes hardened, her expression turned to one of resolve. "I told you before, Catra. I'm not going

back!" Adora declared, the magic glow intensifying with her strong emotions as she refocused her effort upon the Sea Gate.

Catra blinked in surprise, as her attempt to convince Adora to return willingly was so abruptly rejected. Her heartbroken expression quickly twisted into rage. She lunged with her claws, to the left. She-Ra swiftly deflected Catra's strike with her bracer's. As Catra dashed under the Warrior Princess's outstretched arm to slash at her from behind. She-Ra, once again deflected her claws, with her right bracer this time.

Catra wasn't giving up and was going to tag that fucking princess! Who stole her best friend!

Ducking to the side and slightly behind She-Ra, to adjust her strike. Coming at her hard and fast, forcing She-Ra further off balance. Cutting that pompous self-righteous, Princess, just under the elbow with one clawed hand, while slashing her left cheek a second later. As Catra twisted herself inside She-Ra's upraised arms. Lunging out for one well muscled arm, clutching the golden bracer, of the arm holding the sword aloft. Getting right up into She-Ra's face, with a triumphant sneer. Then punched her right in the stomach, with everything she had. Knowing she couldn't do anything to protect herself, if she wanted to keep powering the gate.

She-Ra cried out, gasping for breath as the wind had been knocked out of her.

Catra smugly as she stood beside the breathless 'hero', watching as She-Ra faltered to the knees. Stubbornly, She-Ra adjusted her sword's angle to maintain the magical feed towards the gate from her lower position.

Refusing to submit…refusing to ever give up!

Cannon fire exploded below their earthen platform, as the battle raged on.

Catra prowled behind She-Ra, a predatory glare in her eyes, piercing Adora with a silent threat. Catra had every intention to continue to menace her, that she was enjoying this game. Her claws tracing lightly along the column of She-Ra's thick neck. Promising, more pain if she kept resisting. Slipping her hand from behind She-Ra's neck and clasping her chin tight.

"This is what you left me for! Dress up games and a light show!" Catra accused incredulously. "Your new best friends are nowhere to be seen." Her broken heart masked behind her cruel words " Catra leaned in close to She-Ra's ear. "When did you become so weak…" She snarled heatedly.

Catra's further torment was cut short, as a pillar of water rose up and blasted her off the platform. The magicat cried out in surprise and terror as she was sent careening towards the ocean below.

Adora sighed heavily, in that moment she was relieved to be free of Catra, her chest clenched in sudden fear, as she was also concerned for Catra's safety. The magicat hated water! She was not a strong swimmer. Which was her own fault, for skipping their swimming lessons as junior cadets.

Adora's heart twisted in two different directions. A fracture between heart and mind that she was intimately acquainted with in regard to Catra.

Conditioned to stay focused on her duties, her responsibilities…her pledge to Queen Angella. She was frozen on the platform, waging a silent battle inside herself. Once again, her compassion and need to protect Catra was a distraction. She had to make a choice, jump into the water to make sure her 'best friend', whom she was fighting with, made it safely back to dry land…or finish what she started.

In the end Adora opted to scan the water below, it was all the effort she could give at the moment. Thankfully she found Catra

wading below. Her thick brunette hair was soaked and plastered to her head. Her mask bore a new dent and a few more scratches. Catra just stared up at her. Her sapphire and gold eyes were bleak, wearing an almost resigned expression. Before she swam off, disappearing behind a cluster of jagged rocks further down the narrow beach just south of the Sea Gate's rocky shores. Adora watched her with a sad, resigned frown. Before a massive explosion caught her attention. Debris raining down upon the water, splashing the sea like sudden snowfall. She-Ra snapped her eyes up, finding the Horde warship out at sea. Was now on fire and it sank quickly beneath the waves. A few minutes later, Adora caught sight of Catra again. She had been swimming towards the warship. Now, the magicat was clinging onto a piece of broken decking. Retrieved moments later by a Scorpioni woman, who dragged her away out of view along the coastline.

Adora sighed and nodded, she felt everything had been resolved. So she rose back onto her feet to repair the Sea Gate. Even as her own heart was breaking with how callous she was being. But Adora had to stay the course, she was She-Ra…she had to fight for the greater good and bring down the Horde. The Princess Alliance had to be reformed, she had to keep her word… to Mermista. Adora kept her eyes closed and gave it her all to finish what she had started.

Catra

The sky was bleeding luminescent pastel hues of red and orange, as the Day Moon set upon the far off watery horizon. The clouds huddled in the distance, glowing like coals in the brilliance of the dying light.

Catra stared out towards that endless expanse of water, as the conflicting emotions of sorrow and rage waged a war inside her. She couldn't help the disappointment over how things went with

Adora. She had to admit she came out here hoping that she would stop being an idiot and come home. But as she expected, she never got what she wanted. Once again, she was alone and brooding.

“Hey, there…” Scorpia’s nervous intro, followed the Scorpioni's bulky presence. As her shadow fell over the, soaking wet, Magicat. Currently slumped wearily over her knees and sulking at the stern of Force Captain Octavia’s Warship.

Catra had hidden herself behind the rear bulkhead on the upper command deck. Soon after the octopus hybrid’s crew had fished Catra and her strike team out of the open water several miles out from the Sea Gate.

Days earlier, Catra had refused to board Octavia’s ship, stating she and her team could handle the mission on their own and they didn't’ need Octavia and her crew getting in the way. She had then commandeered her own Warship from the Naval Base. On the Serpentine Straight, leaving Octavia high and dry on the dockyard.

Shaking her scaly green head in disbelief. But the older Force Captain had just let her go, never saying a word. Catra was a hothead and confrontation never went well. But Octavia left the base several hours later, on her own Warship. Already knowing what the outcome was going to be. With a brash, newly forged Force Captain at the helm and a novice crew manning the decks off that Warship. She wanted to be there, when Catra’s mission went down in flames. Wanted to gloat and put that pompous, arrogant brat in her place.

Relishing in Catra’s failure, the octopus hybrid had laughed uproariously. Calling Catra out on her incompetence as a leader. While the rest of Octavia’s crew laughed along with their Captain. Throwing merciless jabs at the soggy Magicat and her soaking wet Strike Team. As once again they had to endure the march of shame across the deck. Octavia called out to Catra, one final threat. That she would file a report on what happened to Central

Command. That her career as a Force Captain had an inevitable expiration date. With yet another lost War Machine under her belt. Shadow Weaver was going to be pissed and Hordak was not going to be pleased either. Octavia promised that If she didn't improve her performance, it was certain that she would be demoted and sent to be reconditioned for the factories sector. With all the other military wash outs.

Catra's ear's had pinned back and her once stiff upright posture, deflated into hunched defeat. As she slunk to the back of the boat and hid behind the command hatch.

"Leave me alone." Catra growled, hiding her face behind her crossed arms. That were braced on her knees, that were tucked up tight against her chest. Folding herself into some impenetrable ball. She was humiliated, frustrated and heart broken. Her first two missions were absolute disasters. If she didn't improve…she was going to be disposed of…that fear shot unbridled panic through the very core of her being.

Leaving her feeling vulnerable and worthless.

She didn't need nor want her new 'babysitter' to barge into her personal space and try and cheer her up. This had been an absolutely horrible day! She had barely been a Force Captain for a couple weeks. How was any of the senior officer's going to take her seriously if she kept screwing up! What little bit of power she had to protect herself, was flimsy at best. It could be ripped away at the slightest whim, by Shadow Weaver…by Hordak…by any of the other Force Captains. She hated feeling this way! She hated not being in control! She hated…she hated…she hated…the uncertainty that always plagued her future.

Scorpia sighed and sat down beside her anyway.

"Look…I know you're upset. " She offered gently, trying to reach out to her with kindness and start a dialog to help her feel better.

Catra merely raised her head and arched an incredulous eyebrow.

“Thanks for your observation, go away.” She answered bitterly.

Scorpia just smiled softly, wiggling her butt to get more comfortable and leaned back against the bulkhead. She wasn’t going to give up, Catra could be volatile and sorta mean. But she knew she could get through to her eventually, one day Catra would see that she could be a good friend.

They both needed….a friend.

Catra groaned, tucking her face back behind the wall of her arms. As her tail curled protectively around her ankles, the tip flicked with irritation.

“Octavia can go suck an egg. She messed up plenty of mission’s herself. “ Scorpia offered, resting a large claw on Catra’s shoulder in solidarity.

“Don’t touch me.” Catra grumbled, flexing her wrist and flashing her claws on one hand towards the Scorpion.

Scorpia quickly pulled her pincher back, casually, crossing them behind her head instead. “We will succeed next time for sure.” Scorpia promised.

Catra sighed heavily. This woman’s optimism was so annoying!

Catra’s eyes narrowed, with new purpose. She was a Force Captain now, she had power…no one would ever make her feel inferior again. She would make sure the rest of the Force Captain’s came to fear her! She just had to figure out their weaknesses and then exploit them. She would never be humiliated like this again.

“You know…fuck this!” Catra punched the deck and jumped to her feet. Her eyes blazed once more with a white hot fury.

“Catra….what…where….” Scorpia was quick to scamper after her. As Catra stormed down the deck straight for Octavia. Who was currently standing at the front of the ship on the wide prow of the forecastle. She was alone, surveying the waves breaking upon the curving metal bow of the ship, as her crew had dispersed to tend to the vessel. A handful were milling around mid deck, some mopping other’s maintaining the ships main laser cannon. But most had gone below to the engine room or up to the bridge in the upper command deck at the stern.

Which suited Catra just fine, she didn’t need nor want an audience. It would only complicate her tactical assault. She could take Octavia. Had already been able to handle that slow, lumbering octopus at six years old. This would be easy.

“Hey, Dumb Face!” Catra shouted, as she charged in low. Claws fully extended as she rushed Octavia. The hybrid turned, her one good eye wide in shock.

As Catra leaped up to the forecastle, ignoring the stairs. Jumping onto the forward railing, pouncing right onto her armored chest from the side with all four sets of claws. Digging into the leather armor and sending the aquatic bulk of Octavia to the deck in seconds.

With the air knocked out of her, Octavia was stunned. Her lower two tentacles were pinned behind her, compressed to the deck by her own body weight. The upper two tentacles were curled limply along her sides. Catra took the advantage, stomping her feet onto the weakly writhing limbs pinning them down to the deck. As Octavia groaned and slowly came alert.

“You fucking, brat!” Octavia snarled, “I’m gonna…” Her threat went silent as Catra’s toe claws clenched into the leathery flesh off her tentacles. Drawing blood, as the razor sharp weapon’s she always had sheathed within her own body. Were powerful enough to pierce the Octopus Hybrid’s thick hide.

“I don’t think so…If you don’t want to lose your other eye. You’ll do as I say, I’m in charge now…” Catra then leaned down close, hissing the rest of what was going to happen to her if she resisted, into Octavia’s frilled ear at the side of her head.

Octavia’s one good eye flew wide in horror, having already suffered a disfigurement at Catra’s claws, she swallowed hard and went limp. Silently, surrendering herself to the magicat.

Scorpia stopped halfway across the deck, when she saw Catra take Octavia down in such a brutally feral way.

“Oh…wow….I understand…” Scorpia gulped. “Yeah…she’s a Wild Cat for sure.”

She totally got why Shadow Weaver wanted her to keep an eye on her…she was a wild card. She had such an intense, untamed rage inside of her. The Scorpion had no idea what Catra might be capable of and it was kinda scary. Scorpia honestly doubted she could keep her in line, even if she wanted too.

S1E6:System Failure

Adora

Just as he promised, Bow joined her in her training. She would find him waiting for her at dawn every morning. At the bottom of the steps of Bright Moon Castle's central gatehouse. Dressed everyday in varying colors of cotton pants and a tight sleeveless crop top and a pair of old running shoes. Even though the air around half moon lake was usually rather cool in the mornings and heavy with moisture. But she had come to know that the young man loathed covering up his stomach. Adora didn’t have

much variety when it came to clothes, not for the lack of trying on Glimmer's part. Glimmer had offered to take her down to the village to expand her wardrobe. But Adora didn't want nor need variety. She had requested a few pairs of long sleeve shirts minus the Horde insignia on the back, and a few more under shirts and shorts and gray pants. That was all she needed and honestly having a daily uniform. Was comforting, she was used to wearing the same thing everyday. She really did not want to deal with the frivolous decisions of picking different clothes everyday. She made enough decision's in the War Room every other day and the Hordes advances along Bright Moon's border's was not slowing down.

So, she would wear her tank top and shorts that she wore to bed for her morning runs. With her red and white combat boots. No longer getting fully dressed like she did back in the Horde. It was a small deviation from her Horde conditioning. But it was enough to start to change her perspective. She was free of the Horde and she was now in control of her own training and how she approached it.

This was yet another reminder of her freedom and she was relishing in small rebellions against her upbringing.

So every morning for the last several weeks, since the Sea Gate. Bow and her would go for a two mile run around Half Moon lake. She could run longer, but Bow barely made it back to the Gate House. He would build up his stamina in time, Adora refused to condition him as harshly as she had been as a child. She would just do this run again in the evening without him, so she could run as long and as hard as she wanted. Then they would return to their rooms, to dress in their daily clothes. Adora never wore her jacket during training, only putting it on later in the morning along with her sword, before their first planning session in the War Room. Setting Adora aside and metaphorically becoming She-Ra.

Meeting up in a lower training yard in the outer battlements of the Castle. The yard was huddled between the guard barracks and the lower ramparts near the gatehouse. So it wasn't a very long trek

through the lower halls of the castle. A large cobblestone yard, with short barrier walls of stone that overlooked the lake. A covered parapet wall, hollowed out the mountain on the other side. That housed some of the guards weapon's. Real weapons were mounted on the stone walls, from axes, swords and spears. Wooden staves and practice swords were set into wide mouthed, clay pots. Bows and arrows were tucked away into large chests. Several compressed hay targets sat on the far end of the yard. Along with a dozen wooden training dummies for weapon's practice. Adora felt right at home in this space. She eagerly took to teaching Bow about physical conditioning. She would instruct the archer how to do push ups, chin ups and various other exercises to build strength and stamina. She would continue doing even more reps, long after Bow finished. He would gather up a bow and a quiver from one of the trunks and begin to practice his aim at the targets. While Adora finished up, then she would grab a wooden sword from a clay vessel and start to reenact the movements she had observed the Bright Moon guards displaying. It was embarrassing but she had begun lurking around the guardhouse and training yards since she first got here. Observing their training regime and trying to mimic it. She had no idea how to use a sword and this was her only means to learn. Since the Bright Moon soldiers were still rather wary of her and the Captain of the Guard, Juliet was still rather cold towards her. She didn't fault her for it, she had to prove herself and she would.

It would be another few weeks until their mission to Dryl. In that time Captain Juliet would finally warm up to Adora and begin to train her with the rest of the Bright Moon Soldiers.

Which went as well as Adora expected…

Several weeks had past, since their eventful trip to Dryl to recruit Princess Entrapta into the Alliance. Adora had increased her training with the Bright Moon Guards, ever since the Sea Gate.

Reporting to Juilet for close to a month now. Sadly, the Bright Moon Soldier's had not warmed up to her at all. Whenever they partnered up around the training yard for weapon's drills. Silently, refusing to spar with her. None of them said anything, filtering away to partner up with everyone else, simply avoiding Adora like she was some kind of pariah. Leaving her to awkwardly stand alone, until Captain Juliet motioned her to join her.

Adora was dealing with being ostracized and distrusted. It hurt, but she swallowed her uncomfortable feelings. Accepting that she would just have to work harder, if she wanted to be accepted. Until then she was grateful, Captain Juliet took it upon herself to pair up with her.

The young soldier's were all dressed in various types of armor, some in pieces of plate others in chainmail or dusk purple leather. Depending on what area of the Bright Moon defensive force they were training for. In the Bright Moon military, you had to earn your armor. By the time you had a full set you were considered fully trained and ready to defend the Castle or head out on military missions.

So Adora now stood in her white long sleeve shirt, gray pants and red and white combat boots. Having only earned a set of dusk colored leather bracers upon her wrists. As She-Ra she didn't really need armor, but Juliet needed to gauge her training in the same manner as the rest of the trainee's. So she chose to bestow Adora pieces of leather armor to illustrate she was earning her place among the Bright Moon military.

Captain Juliet was in her full, gleaming silver plate regalia. Helmet glinting in the morning light, the shiny metal flashing Adora in the eyes as she circled her. The warm season was ending, as the Day Moon was growing brighter. The clear sky was not helping, as the Moon's brilliance was shooting sharp rays off every piece of silver metal armor all around the yard. Adora raised an arm to shield her

eyes for a moment. The air had been growing more humid and muggy as the temperature rose.

Squinting her eyes to watch the long purple tassel, attached to the top of Juilet's helmet, tossing in the wind. The older woman, holding a wooden practice sword, pointed towards her opponent.

"Have you ever used a sword before?" Captain Juliet inquired, as her polished wooden sword clashed with Adora's practice weapon.

"Never…the Horde…" Adora's eyes drifted towards the groups of soldiers fighting nearby, her voice growing softer. "We trained with bow staffs and stun baton's, hand to hand…mostly. By the time we were Senior Cadets we were training with laser rifles and learning to operate the Hordes various war machines." Adora shrugged. Her thoughts once again fell back on Catra, who had joined the Tank brigade in their final years of training. She loved blowing things up! She was an exceptional pilot and a capable gunner. Adora never took to moving well in tight places, so she remained part of the ground troops at the time.

"Good thing you increased your training then." Juliet feinted and swung low with her sword. Adora backed up, adjusted her stance and deflected the sword. With a wide sweeping parry. Knocking it aside, before shuffling to the left. Her blue eyes darted over Juliet's pose, calculating what moves Juliet would make next. As her prowess with a sword was still rather clumsy and blunt.

"Well…I've never backed down from a challenge." The Captain of the guard gave her an eager, almost feral grin. From beneath the metal cowl of her helmet. Her white teeth gleaming in the radiant light, deep brown eyes piercing Adora's with the keen, aptitude of a weapon's master. "I'm gonna have to train you hard to make up for all those missed years." The dark skinned woman backed away, flourishing her sword in a spinning arch with one hand upon the hilt.

“I promise, I’ll make you a sword master by year's end.” Juliet vowed.

Adora stood gaping in wonder as Juliet moved into a fluid, deadly set of movements. Showing off her deadly prowess with the sword.

She could learn that…The Captain of the Guard always knew how to motivate Adora. She grinned eagerly back and assumed a position beside the dark skinned woman. Beginning to shadow her movements as she memorized the pattern.

She was no stranger to hard work and single minded focus upon a goal.

She was going to be the best She-Ra, Etheria ever had!

It was in the quiet hours, when Adora had retreated to her room. When her mind is no longer distracted by the day’s toils. She discards her red jacket in a valiant attempt to force herself to relax and get ready for bed. In the end she would just begin to brood, picking apart everything she had done, everything she had said. As if she was slowly, eviscerating her own self confidence that she could achieve her goals.

Finding herself out on the open balcony of her bedroom, as the night wore on. Leaning against the pearl white railing. She held her wing shaped belt buckle in her left hand. Absently rubbing it with her thumb and index finger. Watching the light fade behind the Whispering Woods and the moons ascend and then slowly cross the dark sky. The various sized orbs glowing within the backdrop of the ribbon’s of light. That she had only witnessed when her strike team had run away to Scorpion Hills. Glimmer had explained to her that it wasn’t the soul’s of the dead, like Tama had told them. But the aura of magic that the Woods gave off that could only be seen when the world grew dark. There was so much she didn’t know, the Horde had been so selective with what they

taught their cadets. Adora chuckled ruefully, she had been truly and absolutely brainwashed by the Horde.

Then her mind would drift towards those blank hours, in which she had been corrupted by the strange disk of Entrapta's. She had no memories, waking up confused and exhausted in Entrapta's lab. A strange uncertainty, plaguing her. Glimmer and Bow had explained that She-Ra had been out of control for a short time and then she transformed back into Adora…who was floppy… whatever the hell that meant! But they would tell her nothing else. Adora leaned heavily on the railing, arms crossed as the weight of her destiny as She-Ra once again grew burdensome. No one here wanted Adora…they only wanted She-Ra. They kept her around because of what she could do, placing all their hopes that she would have the power to tip the balance in their favor. She-Ra's reputation and success in beating back the Horde had spread throughout several kingdom's already. Etherian's were now flocking to Bright Moon. Some for protection, since the Horde had increased their attacks on border villages The refugee encampment on the plateau's across the lake were close to overflowing. Other Etherians were here, trying to catch a glimpse of She-Ra in action. While even more were wanting to be trained, bolstering the rebellion's ranks… the Alliance's war machine was ramping up once more.

"I miss you…" Adora whispered brokenly, her eyes downcast to the shimmering lake beyond her balcony. Her thoughts fell into introspection upon the only person that had ever accepted her as Adora. To her she had been perfect as she truly was, there were no expectations or responsibilities to being her best friend. Not like it was here, in Bright Moon…

She had gone and botched that up…how did she fix this? How did she convince Catra to come over to the good side of this war? Adora never acknowledged the tears, slowly cascading down her face. She merely let them fall, unhindered. As she stared at the gentle waves cresting the shore below.

Still feeling so very lost and alone…in this new life…she had chosen for herself.

S1E7: In the Shadows of Mystacor

Catra

It had been at least a month or more since the Sea Gate. Catra had no time to just sit and brood over what had happened between her and Adora. Being a Force Captain came with a whole new set of challenges that kept her busy. The primary one being, Dominance…Hordak had several Force Captains; they were all the same rank and a pecking order had to be established. It was just like growing up in the bunkroom but the stakes were higher. When each one who opposed her promotion tried to dominate her in some way. Catra had to rise up and put each one in their place early on. She was no novice in the use of fear tactics and intimidation. She had cut her fangs, playing this power game.

It didn't take Catra more than a few weeks to get the other Force Captain's who might get in her way, to back off . Scorpia wasn't even an issue, she followed Catra around like a lost puppy. Hanging off her every word and more than eager to carry out any order. Catra already had Scorpia in her corner, she could already manipulate her easily under the guise of their 'friendship'.

Sorting out Octavia, was much more straightforward. Intimidation was her driving force to get Octavia to submit. The woman already had a good dose of anxiety when it came to dealing with Catra. That the magicat was gleefully aware of. So she dealt with

her back at the Salineas Sea Gate. During their trip back to the Naval base, upon the Serpentine Straight. All she had to do was threaten to slash out her other eye and end her military service, if she didn't show her the proper respect.

The Octopus was quick to pledge her loyalty. So she was no longer a threat. Grizzlor on the other hand was proving to be a pain in the ass. He hadn't taken her seriously at first either. That furball was an old veteran who saw everything in black and white, the right way to do things and the wrong. He didn't like change and definitely did not like how Hordak had just given a senior cadet who barely graduated, a Force Captain's Badge. Just because he was down, a Force Captain and felt the raid upon Thaymor had been a relative success. Even if Shadow Weaver didn’t think so. Hordak was not going to waste more resources in some vain attempt to get Adora back. Thaymor hadn't even been a very big target. Hordak had wanted the people culled and the village destroyed so they could set up a supply depot. Before pushing further into the Whispering Woods.

Gizzlor had voiced his opinion behind closed doors, too much of a coward to take his grievance to either Shadow Weaver or Hordak. Spreading rumors that Catra was just a token Force Captain. That she hadn't earned her rank, that Adora had left and she was just the runner up. He was destroying her reputation before she even had a chance to earn one. It hadn’t helped that the mission’s she had been on had excessive collateral damage, so her rep wasn’t stellar. So the old furbag did have shit to sling. But she still had time to fix things. So he had to be dealt with, before Hordak lost all confidence in her ability to lead.

Her tactics this time were not so straight forward, this time they were subtle and far more cunning. She needed to put Grizzlor in his place, not wanting him to continue to discredit her with the other soldier's behind her back. She had used her natural ability for stealth to trail him for a few weeks, with a voice recorder. Since he liked to complain and degrade her with the other soldier's. She knew it would only be a matter of time before he said something incriminating about Hordak or Shadow Weaver.

That could be used to have him demoted or even executed for treason. But for now she had him up on charges of spreading insubordination and inciting conflicts between squadrons. That earned him being locked in solitary for several weeks in a Fright Zone Prison cell. He had an attitude adjustment about her after that, knowing she would have him under constant surveillance from now on.

She taught Grizzlor to fear her…and for now that was enough.

Even so, Catra may have asserted her dominance over the rest of the Force Captain's. She was still absolutely terrified of Shadow Weaver.

Stuck standing guard outside the Black Garnet Chamber, with her ears pinned and tail quivering between the legs. Valiantly trying to tame the trembling in her limbs.

As hours pass in silent humiliation, as other soldier's pass by her giving her odd looks. Curious to find a Force Captain, doing such a menial chore as standing watch.

Finally, Catra took a deep breath over being Shadow Weaver's watch dog and re-entered the room. Finding Shadow Weaver on the floor of the Black Garnet chamber. Weak and pathetic, with her power shard flickering. Stepping over the crumpled old woman as if she meant nothing. Catra was able to reclaim a little of her dignity that she had lost earlier. Smirking down at the crone as she passes by, to stare curiously down at the swirling dark water in the sorceress scrying bowl.

Earlier, the old crone had once again scared Catra with her dark magic and sent her to stand guard. Pompously, professing that she had got Adora back herself, because Catra was such a failure. She attempted to use some of her shadow spies that she had sent out weeks earlier, to hunt down Adora and bring her back to the Horde. Which obviously, didn't work!

Catra prowled away from the scrying bowl, formulating her next set of moves to take more power. The magicat crouched over her tormentor. Claws fully extended from both her hand and feet. The Sorceress had over exerted herself and now she was vulnerable. The predatory instincts roared to life inside of her. How easy it would be to slash her throat right now…bite her neck…end her… take her place at Hordak's side…

In the end Catra pushed those feral impulses down and left the unconscious sorceress on the cold floor of her chamber instead. She prowled down the corridors with a new plan now churning in her mind, Catra sauntered back to her quarter's to work out the finer details. She understood how well, finding your adversaries weakness and exploiting it was. It was a tried and true method of conquest that she was currently perfecting. Sparkles and Arrowboy were Adora's weaknesses. That was how she was going to win…Adora would do anything to keep Sparkles and Arrowboy safe. She just needed to figure out how to get close enough to them to use them against her.

"Hi…there Wild Cat." Scorpia jogged up beside her, falling silent as she noticed the sly smile creeping upon the feline's face as she was lost in thought.

"Oh…that's your scheming smile…want to share?" Scorpio offered, pincer's clicking hopefully at her breast. "We could brainstorm together, ya know…I'm great at spitballing..we could grab some ration bars and just hangout in your room…" She began to ramble.

"No." Catra snapped, entering her quarters and punching the button at the side of the door. To seal the doors in the Scorpion's face. Not even noticing or caring how the woman's hopeful smile fell into a sad, rejected frown, nor the tears misting in her deep blue eyes.

Adora

“Shadow Weaver control’s us both, she always has.” Catra’s taunting whisper, echoed to her. Drawing her down the dimly lit hallway, illuminated only by the faint glow of the ghostly moon’s. That seemed to reflect through the walls as if they were made of smoky glass.

“Catra…Where are you?” Adora called back, answered by the feline’s soft laughter. That once filled her with warmth and comfort, now sent icy dread down her spine. Yet she still chased after her, following the magicats soft foot falls into the deepening darkness. Just as she had always done in her youth…chase after Catra no matter the danger. Calling out to her, beseeching her to come out…the yearning to see her, talk to her, blossoming in her heart. The hope that this time she will communicate better. That Catra would understand, that this time she would follow her instead. As those positive emotions washed over her. Adora’s body began to glow with a soft golden light. Illuminating the way ahead. Running into the darkness, desperately screaming Catra’s name over and over again.

Catra’s teasing giggle deepened into a low chuckle.

“The Horde had high hopes for you, Force Captain. Disappointing.” Hordak spoke, “Does the rebellion truly think you can save them, nothing can stop the Horde, least of all you….you will lead them all, every Etherian to their complete and utter annihilation. Nothing will be left of Bright Moon but smoking ruins, your friends buried beneath.” His voice was cold, calculating as if he had already seen the outcome and was merely warning her of her own inevitable failure.

Preying upon the fear’s she carried deep inside her heart.

Adora stood frozen, the warm glow fading as fear and doubt seeped into her soul.

“This is all your fault Adora, you're to blame…” Glimmer and Bow’s accusing voices echoed from the now encroaching darkness. As it devoured the last of her meager light.

Preying upon her fragile self worth…that always taunted her deep inside her thoughts.

“No…I…did my best…I tried to be what you wanted…what Etheria needed…” Adora pleaded to the void now surrounding her. Desperate to defend herself, to prove that she was working hard to earn their acceptance. Trying to soothe the burning guilt that always festered like a poison inside her. That she was never doing enough…that she was never good enough…

“Adora…” A sly, silky voice called to her soothingly. As the shadows caressed her cheek in tender affection. Wrapping around her wrists and then slithering up her arms over her shoulders in some disturbing, motherly affection.

“You should have never left, these people do not understand you, nor do they even want to know you. They only want to use you, use your strength as She-Ra! They will never accept you.” Shadow Weaver’s murky silhouette wavered into view before her. She hovered before her, hands outstretched to pull her into a comforting embrace That Adora knew now, was a mockery of motherly devotion, of affection.

Shadow Weaver was cruel and she never…loved her…

Adora sucked in a startled breath, backing out of her grasp and instinctively reaching for the hilt of her sword. In the leather sheath strapped across her back. Finding nothing…

There was a mournful silence, heavy with a sense of the inevitable. Adora was powerless…she was nothing without the sword.

She was nothing….worthless…a failure…weak…

“You know deep down what I say is true.” Shadow Weaver’s voice was tender, but it held no comfort. Just the smug undertones of a teacher who knew she was right and was reveling in her student’s suffering. As they finally learned the hard truths.

Adora gasped, clutching her stomach and crumpling to her knees. Eyes closed and head bowed in defeat.

“ **Ambitious, Cutthroat, Ruthless Warrior…”** Catra’s accusations exploded like bombs going off all around her. Adora jumped to her feet, spinning around and scanning the darkness in desperation. As she felt death looming all around her

Flashes of her childhood, of how fiercely competitive she had been. How she worked tirelessly…obsessively to be the cadet with the highest ranking, never giving up and never giving in. Doing whatever was necessary to win, to be completely indomitable in combat. Standing above her peers, above her rival’s…above Catra…and she achieved her superiority…she deserved Shadow Weaver’s praise, she earned the accolades she received! She was driven and she always strived to become more. She had always wanted more… Which set her apart from every one of them. Because she was special… she had never settled for mediocrity.

“I prepared you for greatness.” Shadow Weaver’s and Adora’s voices intertwined in a declaration towards the darkness that was vibrating with power.

.

“You were nothing until I took you in Adora.” Shadow Weaver’s cruel hands grabbing her arms, holding her tight. “You are nothing without me!” A low, growling voice hissed through the darkness. “You are weak.” It snarled in her ear.

Adora heard herself screaming, her voice breaking at how absolutely terrified she was. Her insides twisting with remorse, revolted by her past self.

The darkness snapped with a brilliant flash of light. As Adora found herself sitting on her cot back in her room in Bright Moon. It was the middle of the night, the moon's were high over the Whispering Woods. Casting her room in a somber, melancholy half light. The sheer white drapes adorning her tall balcony windows, fluttered in the cool night wind. As she was trembling with confusion, huddled within the fragile sanctuary of the pale blue curtains that tented over her cot. Clutching her blanket tight to her chest, as her heart pounded against her ribcage. Unable to find air, panting and groaning as she struggled not to faint. Her sight was blurry, flooded with tears. She could barely make out the pale blue curtain that surrounded her cot…or the sudden burst of sparkles that appeared beside her.

"Adora…" Glimmer gasped in shock, dashing towards the cot. The Princess was disheveled, her short pink hair standing up at odd angles. The thin strap of the pale pink night gown hanging off one shoulder. She rushed to Adora's side, frantic and worried. Pulling the trembling blonde to her chest and holding her head firmly against herself, as her other hand rubbed up and down Adora's arm. Seeking to ground her, anchor her here in this room and not allow her to fly off into the panic that was consuming her.

Adora was stiff, unsure of the affection but did fight it nor pull away. Allowing Glimmer to soothe her, comfort her in all the ways she once received only from Catra. Thinking about Catra was so painful…Adora grit her teeth, locking her jaw to hold back her heartbroken sobs. Refusing to be vulnerable, refusing to be weak. Falling back into the armor she knew best, pushing her anguish down into submission and locking them away. Refusing to deal with any of it, she had to stay focused on her mission. She had no time to break down…over all that she had lost. Fortifying herself with the truths she understood now, that she was free of the Hordes influence.

Shadow Weaver was wrong! She was cruel and she messed with her head…Glimmer…Bow…they were kind and they cared about her. The fact that Glimmer had heard her scream and came to her room without a second thought. Willing to take on the unknown danger, not knowing if Adora was under attack or not. It proved that she was her friend…that she honestly cared about her… Adora.

Glimmer and Bow were good and they were compassionate…and they cared about Adora…

All the wonderful foods Glimmer and Bow had shared with her… getting her a bed that she was comfortable with. The sleepover's to make her feel more relaxed when she first comes to Bright Moon. All the patience, understanding and kindness they have shown her, not only here in Bright Moon but on Mystacor as well. They honestly cared about her well being and wanted what was best for her. The teasing banter, the laughter that they shared during missions or just wandering around Bright Moon or the Whispering Woods.

Their friendship was real!

"Glimmer…" Adora whimpered, finally clutching onto the Princess tight. Trusting her new friend's comfort.

"I'm right here, Adora…I will always be here when you need me." Glimmer promised, petting a hand down the back of Adora's head. Pulling out her ponytail as she swept her fingers down through her sweat soaked blonde hair. Night terror's of this magnitude were not new to Adora, but to Glimmer, seeing how scared and distraught Adora was it was unsettling to say the least.

Adora squeezed her eyes shut tight, Shadow Weaver did not control her anymore! She had stood up to her! Cast her darkness out of her mind, out of her heart, out of her very soul. She promised herself that she would never be like she was back in the Horde. She would learn how to change, she would grow and be a better person. For her friends…for Etheria…and for herself.

Glimmer stayed with Adora for the rest of the night, while the ex-horde soldier finally opened up at least a little about how twisted and cruel her upbringing was at the hands of Shadow Weaver. Glimmer was horrified but she kept her feelings hidden behind a cool, compassionate expression. As she held Adora’s hand and the girl herself through the night.

Part Three

Chapter Notes

Thank you PinkStorm for your comment and all those who left Kudos. This is the longest chapter so far.

S1E8:Princess Prom

Scorpia

One month earlier…

The days were becoming balmy, as the hot season began once again.

The air whispered along the circulation ducks within the walls, a steady dripping drumming in the distance. As the environmental system of this monstrously constructed tower maintained its cool temperature.

Scorpia was concealed in the gloomy recesses of a narrow service corridor. She kept her back to the main hallway behind her. Leaning her shoulder carapace against the bulkhead, head turned towards the window. Staring forlorn out a small oval window that resembled a warped porthole. Seeking to find a bit of solitude within the confines of the Officer Barracks. She was very upset and struggling to hide the tears pooling in her eyes. It was considered a form of weakness, so hiding was a typical Horde reaction.

The section of the Officer Barracks that housed the Force Captain quarters was never a very busy place. The Force Captain’s came

and went regularly. Always out on missions with their strike teams, throughout Etheria. So it was natural that it was so quiet. She hated the quiet…it was never healthy…at least mentally for her. She would get lost in her head and that was never a good place for her to be.

She struggled with depression…ever since she was abandoned here in the Fright Zone. So she avoided feeling negative emotions. Always acting cheerful and beginning each day with affirmations. To ward off the insecurities and doubts about her worth, that plagued her each day.

But today was harder than most, the loneliness at being the only Scorpioni soldier in the Horde had been thrown in her face today. As she had a physical reminder of what she had lost and how inadequate she was. An oversized scroll was pressed into her left pincher, an invitation she was trying to ignore. The last time she had received this invite, she had been maybe nine or ten years old. Enraged by its very existence. She had marched it straight down to an incinerator in the forge and tossed it in! How dare the Princesses of Etheria reach out to her, as if she mattered to them! Where were they when Hordak's battalion of spaceships crashed into the Stinger mountains. Destroying most of their subterranean crown city, as their alien fleet had carved the Stinger Mountains in two. Where were the royal's years later, when Hordak took over her kingdom! Where were they when her people were being slaughtered and driven out by his armies. Where were they when…when…when…her whole world crumbled…she was just a child! When she had been left all alone…abandoned, here in the Fright Zone.

"NO!...." Scorpia reeled back and slammed her pincher into the bulkhead. The scream of rending metal did nothing to calm her, as her claw pierced the wall.

"Ah…damn…I'm probably going to have to fix that." Scorpia moaned, pulling her claw out with a few struggling jerks.

“SCORPIA!” Catra’s shrill yell, rebounded down the small hall. “There you are, I have been looking for you all morning.”

“You have?” Scorpia spun in welcomed surprise, a pleased grin plastered over her face. That unfortunately did not reach her eyes, that were still watery. Catra’s interest in finding her, instantly refocused her away from her turbulent emotions. Her need to please, to do everything she could to make sure Catra never rejected her. Surged inside her heart and Scorpia was more than eager to comply with whatever Catra needed.

“Come with me..you gotta help me brainstorm.” Catra beckoned.

“Right away!” Scorpia jogged after her, eager to be in her presence and be of use to her best friend.

Catra

Scorpia looked around, mildly. Catra’s Force Captain quarters was rather spartan. She had nothing on the walls, yet. But the Horde issue banner hanging at the head of her bed and a blue cadet blanket balled up at the head of her bed. There are absolutely no personal items at all? Scorpia merely shrugged it off, Catra had only moved in a month or so ago. Perhaps she just doesn’t have anything yet she wanted to display. Maybe they could have a sleepover some time and Catra could see how her room was decorated. Give her some ideas as to what she could do with this tiny space that is all her own.

“I’m sick of this! Shadow Weaver failed to get Adora and if Hordak finds out she is disobeying him. She will take us down with her.” Catra has been pacing up and down her Force Captain’s quarter’s venting for over ten minutes now.

Scoropia was mostly focused on what she was talking about, but this was the first time Catra had ever let her in her room. So she was a little overwhelmed by her feelings. She was just so happy! To be wanted…needed even, for the first time ever! She couldn't help the goofy grin plastered over her face as she looked around.

"She's obsessed. What we need to think, is, big picture. It's time for someone new to take over….me." Catra confessed, ears twitching and tail lashing aggressively at the thought. Speaking all this out loud was dangerous, she had only been thinking and conspiring to herself for the last few weeks. This was the first time since Adora, that she was reaching out. Trusting someone else to have her back. But Scorpia had proven her loyalty time and again since she had been ordered to watch over Catra. Always professing how they were 'best friends' and all that junk.

So what the hell right…she couldn't take over the Horde on her own. She needed support... she may need a scapegoat to take the blame if things went wrong…

"So are you in?' The Magicat turned to face the Scorpion sitting on her bed. Her claws digging into the metal bedpost anxiously as she awaited her answer.

"I'm hanging out in your room!" Scorpia declared with a giggle of pure joy.

"Unfortunately, you're the only one I can trust around here." Catra scoffed, hiding her disappointment that her only ally was such a simpleton.

"Because we are best friends." Scorpia professed, with pride. Blushing and ducking her head to the side, demurely.

"Stop being so you…and help me think!" Catra was running out of patience. "I have the beginning of a plan. But it's not enough. I need to capture Adora, so Shadow Weaver doesn't demote me. I

need to impress Hordak, so he will make me the new Shadow Weaver. " She snarled, "How do I do both!" She yelled furiously.

"Why don't you try something at the All Princess Ball?" Scorpia offered. "Every Princess is going to be there. " She unfurled the scroll, more than eager to put this stupid invitation to good use. "So Adora would probably be there too. Oh ... .this year's theme is winter wonderland." She began to read the invite, getting rather excited about it.

"How did you get your claws on this?'" Catra hopped onto the bed and snatched the scroll out of her claws. Glowering down at the invite in absolute disdain at its existence.

"I'm a princess…" Scorpia shrugged.

"You're a PRINCESS!" Catra exclaimed, her hackles raising and tail fluffing and thrusting out straight in surprise.

"Yeah you know, the Horde crash landed in my family's kingdom. We let them stay, my family gave Hordak our Rune Stone, the Black Garnet " Scorpia responded, making light of the brutality of how it really happened.

"You're a princess…" Catra was dumbfounded, crumpling the scroll in her fists as she leaned close to Scorpia. Her eyes narrowed in disbelief, as she slowly scrutinized the Scorpioni. Debating if she was lying?

"Oh, man. I thought everyone knew. It's covered in Force Captain Orientation." Scorpia rubbed the back of her head nervously, as Catra was getting way too close to her.

"I am beginning to think I shouldn't have skipped that." Catra mused, handing her back the scroll. As her devious mind began to spin anew. She knelt on the mattress, index claw tapping her lower lip as she worked out all this new information. "Ok. You're a princess and you are going to a princess ball."

“Oh, no… I’m not going, no one liked my family. Even before we joined the Horde.” Scorpia began to explain, “Ah..I never fit with the other princesses. I made them uncomfortable. They don’t like that.” She bowed her head, as the heavy feelings of rejection and worthlessness hung over her once again. The thick gloom of despair was quick to envelope her, smothering her cheerfulness. As she frowned and stared despondently down at the floor.

Not noticing the concerned, sympathetic expression Catra was bestowing upon her. As if the magicat could connect with Scorpia’s feelings of being different, of being ostracized by her peers.

“They don’t like me…” Scorpia admitted sadly. While Catra’s pensive frown turned to a spiteful grin.

“That is exactly why you have to go. How dare those princesses pretend they are better than you. “ Her eyes gleamed with a need for vengeance, “ Just because you're different.” she stood up and braced her hand on her hip, indignant on Scorpia’s behalf for how unjustly she had been treated. “ How dare they abandon people..” She continued, righteously. Balling a hand into a fist, no longer speaking on just Scorpia’s behalf. Channeling her own righteous fury, towards Adora. At being rejected… “Just because they don’t fit in with their perfect little lives.” She was finally verbalizing all the hurt and disillusionment she had been keeping inside. About how unjustly she felt Adora had treated her. All their miserable lives here in the Horde. The emotional release was primal and long overdue. Her pupils contracted with fury, claws fully extended. “How dare they take best friends and turn them into giant sword ladies. Who run off with people who are clearly inferior to you.” Her anger twisting, no longer blaming just Adora but the Princess’s as well. As if perhaps Adora had been brainwashed by the magic? Unable to come to terms that in the end Adora hadn’t chosen her…that she didn’t need her…didn’t want her. That she had wanted her shiny new sword and her sparkling new friends and her great destiny. Which did not include Catra.

"You are telling my whole life with your words." Scorpia was totally enamored by the fierce passion Catra possessed. Holding her pincher's against her cheeks and gazing up at her in awe.

"Well it's time to show those princesses a thing or two." Catra was on fire! She pointed a finger at her. "You're going, I'm coming as your plus one and we are going to make this a night that no one will ever forget." She declared with an earnest grin.

"Super pal duo is going to prom!" Scorpia was ecstatic, standing up on the bed too and wrapping Catra up in a firm hug.

Catra instantly went stiff, arms pinned to her sides and hands balled into fists. But after having to endure this woman's forced affection several times already. She was learning to take it in stride, just closing her eyes and resigning to it.

Her 'hugs' never lasted long…

Three weeks to Prom…

Scorpia

"I know there's not much to look at, really." Scorpia shrugged and chuckled awkwardly. The faint blush on her cheeks, spoke of how nervous she was about what she was sharing. This was the first time she had ever taken someone into the depths of Horror Hall.

The long abandoned stronghold of her lost kingdom had always been her sanctuary. A crumbling ruins deep beneath the Fortress,

left to weather the year’s like a slowly decaying corpse. A time capsule in many ways of her family's last days. The molding detritus of overturned furniture in shadowed rooms, books more dust then paper littered the floor of the royal library. Small toy’s hiding within the clutter of broken lamps and discarded clothes. Illustrating the chaos and mass exodus of the royal servants as they sought to escape. As the Horde invaded the Castle.

The great hall held so many long forgotten treasures, murals and mysteries of her lineage. It was a sacred place, the tomb of her grandmother and mothers. Their skeleton’s still lay inside the old Black Garnet Chamber where they were killed over a decade ago. Horror Hall was a realm of ghosts, some kind that whispered dear, memories of her childhood. While others howled with torment and unrest at how brutal and bloody those last few years had been. As the Hordak, like some viral parasite slowly took over her kingdom.

Scorpia barely remembered her time as a Princess of the Scorpini Kingdom. In some ways she was thankful, but deep down she yearned to remember. To peel back the scales of trauma that kept those moments hidden behind the mists of time. She does not go to the throne room anymore. Shadow Weaver had banned her as a child from entering Horror Hall, but that old woman’s threats never deterred her. She just grew more sneaky, when she needed to escape for a while and hide in the rubble of her old life.

Resolute in her decision, Scorpia was leading Catra down grungy, corridors that lay rotting within the bowels of the Fright Zone. Her routes mapped in her mind, from years of exploration. She couldn’t handle taking Catra to the throne room, where the portraits of her family would stare at them with faded hollow eyes. It was also too close to the Rune Stone chamber that once held the Black Garnet. Their friendship was still so new, far too fragile to endure Scorpia breaking down into ugly tears about losing her family. One day, perhaps…Scorpia would feel secure enough in her relationship with Catra to open up about her grim past. So instead she took the more ‘scenic route’ down the outer side halls.

Catra's eyes darted around, taking in the desolation of the crumbling halls. A sense of foreboding, hanging in the stale air like a dirge. Speaking mournfully about the heinous tragedies these halls had seen during the final days off Scorpia's Kingdom. As the Horde conquered her kingdom so long ago. A shiver went up her spine, as her hackles rose, claws unsheathing and tail lashing. This place felt haunted and it was unnerving. The scorpion usually never shut up, always nattering on and on about stupid stuff no one cared about. But Scorpia had become practically monosyllabic since they entered the labyrinth. Speaking in a whisper and barely more than a couple words at once. Which only made this place even more creepy.
"How are you doing…Big Gal." Catra swallowed thickly, she promised herself she would not get close to anyone ever again. Reaching out in this way, was going against her vow. She grit her teeth, silently chastising her callousness. Scorpia deserved a little compassion. Was she really so bitter and jaded, she would deny someone even a sliver of kindness. When it was obvious how much this place was affecting them. Scorpia had been off ever since leading Catra inside the catacombs beneath the Fortress. She was too quiet, too introspective. She knew the signs of someone getting lost inside their head and how if they were not drawn back to the real world. They could easily spiral into a massive panic attack. She knew from years of experience…thanks to Adora.

"I'm fine…" Scorpia turned back, flashing Catra a tight smile over her armored shoulder.

Catra releases a slow breath, at Scorpia's pathetic attempt to seem unaffected. As the deep blue of her eyes had darkened into an abyss of hidden misery. That Catra with her keen eyesight saw very clearly even in this murky half light underground.

"Look…if this is too hard for you. We can go back, I can figure something else out?" Catra offered, chucking a thumb back down the gloomy hallway behind them.

“Nah, you want to keep this mission secret, I get that. So you can’t requisition Horde equipment without getting found out. I can help…” Scorpia nodded, her eye’s hardened with resolve as she strode onward. Her long legs pacing more quickly down the twisting corridor, forcing Catra to practically sprint to keep up to her.

Catra glanced up at the Scorpioni, briefly as she jogged beside her. Something had changed between them since Scorpia had opened up a little in her quarters about being a Princess. Her eagerness to right the wrongs that were done to her as a child by the Princesses had unintentionally formed a bond between them. They were both spurned by a princess. They were both hurt and united in this mission of revenge.

Catra punched Scorpia in the shoulder, seeking to distract her from her churning thoughts.

Scorpia stopped, turned and arched an inquisitive eyebrow.

“Thanks…or whatever…” Catra stumbled, “I know coming back here is tough.”

“Ah, well…yeah…it is…but you need a vehicle, capable of being stealthy and also fast. I got one. So let’s do this!” Scorpia raised an enthusiastic claw. Her eyes lit up with pride, as Catra grinned brightly up at her.
The crumbling corridor stretched onward, the moisture and rot stagnant in the air. Making Catra rub her nose with the palm of her hand to mask the foul scent with her own. Slowly the halls began to ascend, then wound in tight circles in what seemed to be an outer tower. Stepping lightly over broken glass and moldy tapestries, shredded and faded, littering the edges of the staircase. Long slender window’s carved from stone, with broken shards still embedded into the frames trailed upward beside them as they mounted the steps. She could see fragments of the barren landscape that surrounded the Stinger Mountains.

Finally, Scorpia led her through a massive granite archway into what looked like a hanger bay. With a high arching ceiling, lined with ebony granite carved pillars along each side to hold up the domed roof. The far end of the hanger opened up, onto a breathtaking view of the rust stained desolation beyond the fortress. They are very high up, perhaps close to the shattered peak?

Catra's mouth fell open in awe and slight disappointment. At the bug shaped, broken down vehicles that lay scattered within the bay.

"What are these things?" Catra spat, waving her hand at the scorpion shaped carrier's. They were scattered around the open floor. All in various states of decay, rusting and covered in a thick layer of dust.

"These belonged to my kingdom's military…they were called Scorpion Cruisers." Scorpia shrugged, "I think if we could get one up and running, it would make a great escape vehicle for Prom."

"I know just the right woman to get one of these hunks of junk airborne again." Catra rubbed her hands together, her scheming smile curling upon her lips. Then she promptly tapped her Horde com badge.

"Force Captain Catra to Levi, come in?" She commanded, directing the communication to Levi"s com pad.
"What cha, need. Captain." Levi's responded in a far to casual manner…it wasn't quite respectful but it was borderline. Catra's eyes narrowed.

"Get your tool box, I got a job for you and Max." She ordered, crisply.

One Week to Prom…

“Atila how far out are you, from the fortress?” Catra tapped her badge, as she walked briskly out of the Force Captain’s barracks. Instantly, she groaned in disgust and slapped her hand over her mouth, when the outer doors hissed open. As she was assaulted by the fetid stench of the refinery. Leaving the shadowed confines of the indoors behind, she was suddenly assaulted by the burst of natural light. Shooting down at her like laser beams through a narrow break in the low flying smog. Causing her eyes to squint. She had been hiding indoors for days, seeking to avoid this chemical haze when it had sunken to ground level. It was thick, most day’s, blocking out the Day Moon. But today the putrid fog was lifting, wrapping around the highest points of the fortress now. The Horde was going through a major build up, preparing to push their border’s once again. She didn’t know why or what the target was going to be. She wasn’t high enough in rank to be privy of those battle plans and she didn’t care.

She had her own war to wage.

Catra quickly left the bulbous tower of spaceship hulls that served as the Officer Barracks in the distance. As she headed down the wide streets of the Command sector. Runner’s darted through the heavy traffic of cargo transports and flatbed shaped equipment shuttles. As she made her way towards the less bustling roads of the Training Sector. Heading towards the outer ramparts that guarded the Scrapyard which lay in the distance as solid black walls.

The last three members of Red Beta had just reported in after being silent on the com’s for nearly two weeks. The secret recon mission Catra had sent the other strike team on to the Kingdom of Snow was finally coming to an end. Atila better have the information he was sent to obtain.

“About fifteen minutes out, Force Captain Catra.” Atila’s tired voice responded.

A very pleased grin spread over Catra's face at the sound of her title. Her smile evaporated to a determined scowl. " Did you infiltrate Castle Chill?"

"Yes…." The Tauran's voice was tentative. He was hiding something.

Catra groaned and rolled her eyes. "You better have! I want to see those Castle plans, meet me in the scrapyard at my new den." Catra ordered, cutting the com line with a sharp tap of her claw. With a growl of frustration she already knew, Atila, Otis and Sara's efforts were not going to meet her expectations. Levi and Max had been ordered to resurrect that junk pile of Scorpia's in that old hangar bay in Horror Hall. Which left Red Beta down two member's. Levi was that strike team's leader, but with her out. Atila had to take charge as the team's second in command. This was his first mission, his first time leading. She had no time to send out Red Alpha, like they could do better without her leading them. As it was Lonnie and Scorpia were training to fly that Cruiser. So she would have to make due with whatever Castle plans, Red Beta managed to bring back.

Six hours till Princess Prom

Red Alpha

Preparation for the covert mission had started weeks ago. With Lonnie having to take a crash course in how to pilot a Scorpion Cruiser. She was the only viable candidate out of the remaining three members of the Strike Team. Because Rogelio wasn't going, he would stick out too much. Also, Lizard-kin being cold blooded and all, he would not survive in that frozen wasteland. Catra didn't trust Kyle to tie his shoes correctly, let alone fly a complicated

airship. Even if it was an ancient relic from Scorpia's Kingdom. So Scorpia had gone up to Horror Hall and dug out the old schematics and training manuals for Lonnie and herself to study. While Catra booked the holo-simulator for the both of them to practice in the cockpit for twelve hours every day until the Prom. But Kyle still had his uses. After the mission to Salineas, Kyle had enlisted himself in the sniper core of the Infantry. Catra never questioned it, she just signed off on specialist training as his Force Captain. Now she intended to put those months of target practice to good use.

The invitation had been obscenely complicated. With royal etiquette, rituals and polite greetings for each member of the Etherian royalty , including the Hostess. Catra had memorized only what she needed to get by and ignored everything else. Along with having to hand in any weapon's at the coat check, they also had to reserve a parking spot for their transportation. They needed to arrive as normal, regular royal's so as not to raise suspicion. Which worked for Catra, as their means of a quick escape needed to stay incognito anyway.

So Scorpia and Catra had left in the morning in a retrofitted runner. Another passion project of Levi's, Catra had found out about. Enlisting the new vehicle as their chariot to the ball. Levi had been rebuilding it from a junker in the scrapyard for the last few months. It was similar to a skiff, but didn't have a sail. With two mid-sized rotor blades jutting out on either side of the curved metal hull, creating a cushion of air that the sled traveled on. It wasn't controlled by a rudder, but had a pilot's seat and steering wheel. With inlaid plastic benches along the back hull for passenger's, that she ripped out so it would have cargo space. Catra had ordered Levi to modify it even more, needing it to endure the harsher climate of the Kingdom of Snows. So Levi had put in a passenger seat beside the driver's, along with a side compartment between the seats for storage. She had also covered the open seats of the sled with metal sheeting. Encasing the whole middle section into a bubble shaped cockpit. She mounted

two larger gas tanks at the back. Since the Runner's were mainly used within the Fright Zone and not meant to be on long journeys. They were just basic strike team transports within the Fortress. She also installed tiny vents, shunting the engines excess heat into the covered cockpit. So the occupants would not freeze to death, as they crossed the frozen tundra to Castle Chill. With all those upgrades it was now just big enough for two people.

So several hours later. Lonnie and Kyle ascended up the stone tower, to the ancient hangar bay in Horror Hall. Where the Air cruiser was docked. Taking off by mid morning, after Lonnie had checked and rechecked all her instruments.

They had been in the air for nearly forty-five minutes. The desolation below them had slowly turned to forest. Flying at a high altitude, when they reached the northern edge of the Whispering Woods. The rocky peak of Sky Dancer Mountain rose out of the lush green canopy in the far east. A very obvious landmark of where Bright Moon Castle lay.

Lonnie banked the Scorpion Cruiser westward. Soaring into the open tundra of wide open lands that stretched as far as the eye could see. Kyle had his face plastered to the side of the huge foreward window, marveling at the rocky wilderness below. "Are we in the Kingdom of Snows now?" He asked nervously.

"Just passed into it, yeah." Lonnie answered, flicking a switch on the control dash just to the upper right of the aviator wheel. Then pulled the throttle level in the console beside her down slightly to adjust their speed. The cruiser was simple enough, the three pincher shaped thrusters on the side provided lift. While the rearing tail at the back had a series of rotors to push the craft forward.

Kyle turned to face her, nibbling on his lower lip. They were both dressed for the cold, in heavy smoky gray snowsuits with fur lined hoods. Lonnie never looked away from the forward window. Her

bare hands clenched tight to the steering wheel. A few weeks of training was not enough for her to feel confident. So she was being hyper vigilant to all the aviator dials, which glowed on the massive display dash in front of her. Along with keeping an eye on where she was flying.

Catra would kill her if she drove them into a mountain!

Kyle whimpered and returned to staring out his side window. A heavy anxiety enshrouding him. Catra had been demanding a-lot from her Strike Team since her promotion. The mission to Plumeria had been rather pointless. The Horde post had been demolished by plants…there was no way to get the chemical equipment up and running again. The trees were healed and the natural barrier was back to block the Horde advancement. Since She-Ra had blown the whole operation to smithereens. Their next mission had been to Salineas. Catra had refused to share the mission with Octavia's naval squadron, who were experts at sailing a warship. Stating that her own squadron was capable of sailing a Warship, themselves. Which was a total lie! They had pretty much winged the whole operation. Which ended up going pear shaped far too quickly, they barely knew how to drive the ship and fire the cannon. They were definitely not prepared to take on Princesses! So once again, Kyle was fighting for his life…and losing badly.

This whole rushed training situation they were in again, did not fill Kyle with much confidence. He was more scared now than ever, since they were ordered to infiltrate a whole Castle full of Princesses!

"Relax, Kyle." Lonnie soothed. "We are not going to be near any of those Princesses."

"I know." Kyle muttered, he was rattled…after narrowly surviving two encounters with Princesses.

"Our parts are easy. Scorpia and Catra are doing all the heavy lifting. All we gotta do is take out a couple guards, disguise ourselves in their uniforms and take their places at the ballroom

doors. We're back up, Kyle! To make sure no one leaves the ball, to interfere with Scorpia's part of the plan. Then we wait in the Cruiser at the rendezvous point for Catra ." Lonnie advised.

"I know…" Kyle mumbled, he just couldn't help his nerves. But he was a soldier, he was capable of pushing his fear aside. He would focus on his part of the mission and do the best he could. He glanced over to his sniper rifle, leaning against the wall of the back cargo hatch just under the rear window. It had a long, narrow muzzle and a short shoulder stock, the trigger was tucked up into an oval guard. Retrofitted with a laser scope for added accuracy and a tripod underneath for stability. Since he would be positioned several thousand meters away from the Castle on a neighboring peak.

This would be his first kill…honestly he became a sniper so he could be a safe distance from combat. He never really thought it through…Kyle sighed heavily at the grim realization.

He was a soldier… but his heart had never been in it…he never liked combat.

Dusk was setting in, when they finally left the lonely, desolation of the tundra behind them. Moving into a rocky plateaus of slowly ascending foothills that were the beginnings of the looming mountains on the horizon. Slowly, rising from the barren steppes in the distance. A jagged silhouette appeared against the rugged skyline. Peeking out sharply through the gray mist, settling over the peaks. Was a vast mountain range that cut through the very heart of the Kingdom of Snows. This massive chain of mountains cut across the Kingdom of Snows, slowly descending south along the edge of the Bright Moon Highlands, known as the Barrier Mountains.

Kyle was in awe of the crystalline hues, of the ice that covered the upper reaches of the mountains. As the somber tones of twilight fell, when the Day Moon set. The icy peaks became luminous, reflecting the dying light in piercing flashes as they flew by. The

angled facets began to shimmer and glow, amid the crags of the upper ridges.

“It’s showtime!” Lonnie exclaimed, as the cruiser soared over the last set of mountains and Castle Chill came into view ahead.

The ancient, ice encrusted citadel. Was ascending into the majestically glowing sky, upon a wide, rocky plateau. It was an imposing sight, all sharp lines and smooth ice. Carved from an entire mountain itself. The upper spires flanking upon the wider pinnacle of the main keep, thrust into the sky like long knives. The lower, more robust bastion’s and jutting outer ramparts, blended naturally into the mountain side. A long, curving ice bridge led up from the tundra to the central gates .Which were hidden within a massive guardhouse with a sentry tower, set just above.

Castle Chill was formidable with its many layers of fortifications. It was going to be difficult to sneak into let alone find an obscure point on those covered battlements to find a couple targets?

“Well…that place is kinda scary looking.” Kyle swallowed.

Lonnie merely grunted in acknowledgment as she circled a mountain just to the south of the castle looking for a plateau big enough to land.

One hour till Princess Prom

Catra

Catra lounged as best she could in the driver's seat of the Runner. Sitting slightly sideways, with her bucket seat pushed all the way

back. Propping her legs up and crossed over the forward dash. Smoothing her hands down the pleats of her wine colored dress pants. She was acting calm and unfazed, but her hands were clammy. The front glass of the windshield had been modified from a cargo transport. A narrow stripe of glass, embedded inside a sharply angled metal cab. Catra had just enough of a view to spy incognito on the other royal's pulling in around them in the parking lot. Which lets be honest, was just the huge patch of tundra that stretched out before the Castle.

The cab wasn't exactly spacious, with Scorpia sitting beside her. The cab was on the verge of being claustrophobic. The big gal had to practically fold herself up into the passenger seat. Her head was brushing the low roof and her knees were tucked up tight to her chest. She never complained, not even once during the long drive up to Castle Chill. Their conversations during the trip had dipped into shallow waters of small talk, but every time it got too personal. Catra would refocus them on reviewing their goals, the contingency plans and how to deal with any variants to said plans. Deflecting every one of Scorpia's attempts to get to know her better.

Catra tapped her bare foot anxiously on the dash. The black silk open toe and heel stockings she wore slid smoothly over the arch of her feet. She was remarkably pleased at how comfortable this entire suit was! She never questioned where or how Scorpia had managed to find formal wear in a military base.

They both had been formally dressed for hours! Having had to drive all the way up to the Castle from the Fright Zone. It had been a long and annoying trip. As she had to constantly console or affirm their righteous purpose to Scorpia. Who had been growing more uncertain as the drive wore on. Swinging from guilt about what they were going to do, nervous about not fitting in and reliving the rejection she had suffered as a child. Finally, as the Castle came into view. The Scorpioni's nerves had cooled from that desperate fear, to a firm resolve that these princesses had this coming to them. Catra glanced over to Scorpia, a slow smile of pride spreading over her lips. Finding the Scorpion staring out

the narrow window, up at the Castle. The thirst for payback, burning in her eyes, as she absently tapped the heat bombs on her belt with a claw.

Catra blew on her freshly painted claws, the black varnish gleaming like polished stone in the half light of twilight. She had parked their modest looking transport in the open tundra before the winding ice bridge that led up to the Castle. With the rest of the royal carriages, that was far less high-tech. Keeping a close eye on the various other carriages as they rolled past their parking spot. Sneering and scoffing at their opulence and the strange beasts pulling them. Some had regal looking horses, ferocious arctic cats, massive, furry bovines. They were all decked out in matching bridles and full armored barding to match the carriages they pulled. Then a burst of sparkles appeared near the base of the long ice bridge.

Catra's eye flared with irritation. As Glimmer and Adora appeared and began to walk up the bridge in their formal dresses.

"This is going to be fun." Catra muttered, as a slow sly smile pulled upon her lips.

Princess Prom

Hour one

Adora

Preparing for this evening had been overwhelming and exhausting. She had spent a whole month researching the royal's who would be attending, memorizing the invite that was

obnoxiously long and overly detailed about everything from how to bow, how long to bow and when to curtsy instead of bow…it was soooo complicated.

Adora had tried to get excited about this event, but she just couldn't get past the anxiety. The importance of gaining an alliance with Princess Frosta's would be monumental to their war efforts. The kingdom of Snows was the largest kingdom and it had the largest army. Which would boilster the Rebellion's ranks on par with the Horde. With the extra manpower they could finally start to push back. Against the Horde's relentless assaults along the border of Bright Moon. Able to increase patrol's guarding Plumeria and Dryl from further incursion of Horde troops. They could even send several battalion's to Salineas to help Mermista keep the Horde Naval assaults at bay. The rest of the royal's would be sure to follow, wanting the added protection the alliance could offer. All the benefits of Frosta's allegiance to the cause, was on constant replay in her mind. Making her tense and mission focused ever since arrival.

She had a small panic attack at the coat check, struggling to leave her sword behind. Glimmer never really understood how not having a weapon triggered her insecurities. Or her faltering self esteem, when she had to be simple, plain, Adora. Knowing how everyone loved She-Ra.

Glimmer was quick to intervene before Adora made more of a spectacle of herself. Guiding her towards the ballroom, laughing off how absolutely insane Adora had been acting about her sword. Adora was quick to force herself to calm down, as she took in the grandeur of the Castle. As they walked down wide hallways of carved ice, to the Great hall. Her eyes staring in wonder at the massive mural's similar to Bright Moon. Etched into the granite of viewing alcoves on either side. Adora had no time to really get a good look at any of them, as Glimmer pulled on her elbow when she slowed down. Needing to keep up with the guests, slowly follow the milling crowds up to a grand staircase and then down another huge central hallway to a set of massive double doors. That was currently open, revealing only a little of the ballroom

within. Adora eyed each stranger as they passed, reviewing her extensive research to try and recognize them. But Glimmer never slowed down, clasping her hand when she slowed at the entrance. To try and introduce herself to two young women, milling before the doors. They were identical twins, with soft rounded features, in pale blue skin tones. Their eyes were a piercing, silver blue, giving them a strange yet alluring aspect to their almost otherworldly beauty. With long ivory hair, pulled and twisted into elaborate braids that fell in elegant knots. Either down the right or left sides of their heads. Both dressed in matching silk, white gowns that sparkled under the glow of the ice. She recognized them as the Star Sister's.

"Hi…" Was all, Adora managed to blurt out, as Glimmer pulled her past the two princesses and through the grand doorway. She never even got the chance to see the odd look they gave her or how they instantly began to whisper and giggle to each other.

Adora's breath was taken away, by the sheer size of the ballroom itself. It was two stories, with open balconies wrapping around either side of a cavernous room. That was gorgeously cut from ice. With smooth, elegant pillars carved out of grand icicles along the east and west colonnades of the massive dancefloor. That led to the dais that Frosta's throne sat upon. It was majestic, with smooth curving arms and a wide back in teardrop shape. Local flora from the mountain's decorated the throne and accented the pillars. Their petals were a pale blue or silver, interlaced in delicate chains of snowflakes. The multi-colored crystals, encrusted to the doomed roof, were enchanted. To refract a series of colored light and pulse across the dance floor. As soft music thrummed through the air, falling around them gently like snow.

"Wow…." Adora exclaimed in a rush of air.

Glimmer giggled, taking her hand and leading her down the central staircase into the ballroom below.

The crowds far exceeded what Adora had expected. Which instantly set off her tactical training when infiltrating large groups.

Her eyes darted around, calculating and strategizing all the points of entry and exits.

Half an hour later…

It had taken just two minutes to screw it all up!

Glimmer had promised they would have a good time, but she was being weird about Bow coming with Perfuma. Adora didn't know how to deal with that, so she focused on trying to fix her rude behavior with Frosta. Trying to apologize to the young monarch and strike up a cordial conversation about joining the Alliance. Which she ended up failing at, miserably.

Now she was brooding on a couch in the upper balcony with Glimmer. Who was now spying on Bow and bemoaning all the ways in which their friendship was falling apart.

"Why does it bother you so much?' Adora asked, softly. She had been concerned for Glimmer all night, but had no time until now to get to the bottom of why Glimmer was so upset.

"It doesn't. Bow can hang out with whoever he wants. It's just …" Glimmer sighed in defeat, flopping her arms over the side of the balcony and pressing her forehead into the railing. Seeking to hide her tortured expression. "I never had that many friends...Ok." She slowly raised her head as she confessed her insecurities. "It's always just been me and Bow. But now, what if he likes his new friends better than me. What if everyone does!" Glimmer moaned in despair, once more hiding her tears away in her crossed arms on the balcony.

"That's not going to happen. " Adora's sympathetic frown warmed into a soft smile as she reassured her. Placing her hand on

Glimmer's shoulder, tenderly. " That's not going to happen, Glimmer. Trust me, Bow isn't the type to just leave his old friends behind… " Her expression turned to shock, "And neither am I" her voice stuttered. As the hypocrisy of her very own words were just thrown in her face. As Catra and the Scorpioni entered the ballroom, arm in arm, through the ornate double doors below.

Catra

So far everything was going to plan. They blended in seamlessly with the rest of the ball gowns and suits entering the main gates. Lingering in the entry hall, as they waited for the line in front of the coat check to disappear. Catra wanted to be fashionable late, anyway. Wanting to make an impression on a certain blonde people pleaser, she knew would be inside. She also didn't want any witnesses in case someone figured out they were scoping out the weapons.

Scorpia distracted the guard at the coat check, with innate questions about weapon's regulations and what was and was not allowed inside the ballroom. All while pulling out all manner of dagger's. Catra had strategically hidden on her person. The magicat had instructed her to take her time, to make sure she kept the guards' attention. Scorpia could be rather bumbling, so when she dug out the one hidden between her breasts. It made the guard choke on his own spit. When she accidentally flipped it in her pincher, sending the knife point straight past his head and embedding itself into the floor at his feet. Catra had to bite her cheek not to laugh, as the Guard had gone absolutely pale and a sheen of sweat was clearly visible upon his face.

"Oh…wow. I didn't mean to do that. I'm really sorry." Scorpia apologized, rubbing the back of her neck nervously.

The guard merely nodded, then swallowed hard.

As she then slowly bent over, taking her time to unlatch another from a holster concealed just under the slit of her long black dress. Obliviously, thrusting her cleavage into the guard's face, who was now turning a bright shade of crimson. This time she had a firm grip on the tiny hilt and set it down nicely on the counter.

Scorpio slid her gaze towards Catra briefly, who was leaning against the side of the counter. She had already stated to the guard that she had no weapon's and was now just enjoying the show.

"One…more." Scorpia nodded. As she reached for another from the underside of her well muscled bicep, as she flexed her arm slowly. It was hidden just under the strapped sleeve on her right arm. Setting it down and waiting a beat, before suddenly remembering another dagger and then another and then another.

Catra arched an eyebrow, wondering if Scorpia even knew what she was doing? Scorpia really had the ability to be a sexy bombshell when she wanted. The poor man was so flustered, stuttering out vague answers, as he was overwhelmed by an arsenal of small weaponry all over his counter.

Catra snickered, as she leaned casually at the side of the counter, scanning the weapon's mounted at the back searching for She-Ra's Sword. Once she found it, hanging from a hook near the top most edge of the weapon's display. She gave Scorpia the signal. Which was clasping the ends of her untied bowtie and pretending to adjust it. Scorpia caught the signal and with a nod, she quickly disengaged from the conversation. Catra took her elbow, cordially as they departed. Whispering the Swords location on the massive display to Scorpia for retrieval later.

Their slow if cautious walk across the ballroom had been uneventful, so far. Which was a bit of a disappointment for her.

She had to admit she was eager to mess with Adora. Been looking forward to it for a month.

The cluster's of royal's they passed, never even recognized them. Her ears twitched as she listened to the pedantic banter of the princesses and their respective dates. As they talked about how gorgeous the decorations were, how amazing the food was, commenting on who was wearing what. As if any of that mattered! It was all so trivial and stupid!

Her long dark tail swayed slowly, as they walked. The very tip snapping in agitation as she could feel Scorpia trembling. Her arm was still hooked over the Scorpion's claw. She knew from their long talk getting here, how nervous she was about not fitting in. This late entrance had put them both on display in front of the crowds and it made the Scorpion on edge. But it needed to be done, they had to get Adora's attention. Catra needed to keep her distracted, she posed the biggest threat to her plans.
"Relax…Big Gal. We got this…have fun, enjoy yourself and then… just as the first dance starts ...Disappear…" Catra slid a cunning glance up at Scorpia.
"We got this. " Scorpia nodded, affirming for herself that she couldn't screw this up as long as Catra was on her team.

"We got this." Catra affirmed, giving Scorpia's claw a firm squeeze with her hand. Silently, reassuring her that she had her back. As they headed across the dancefloor to the throne, to greet their hostess.

"Revered hostess.." Adora charged up the steps of the dais.

Just as Catra and Scorpia had finished mounting the steps and had assumed the proper posture to bow and greet Frosta.

"You can't let them in…they're from the Horde." Adora declared in a breathless rant. She had literally sprinted from the balcony,

down the grand staircase and across the ballroom, attempting to intercept them.

Catra turned to her with a mild indignation, at her interruption. Her tail swished once, but she maintained a blank expression, as she regarded Adora. Staying in mid bow, with one arm cocked behind and one cocked across her waist. Maintaining her respectful pose. Silently cheering, that Adora had taken the bait.

"Revered Hostess, Princess Scorpia was invited as per the rules of this ball. Rules which I personally have the utmost respect for." Catra regarded Frosta humbly, closing her eyes and smiling as she lied through her teeth.

"You do not!" Adora screeched, balling her hands into fists as her sides and scowling at the magicat. Catra couldn't be trusted, she was far too cunning.

Catra refused to engage, maintaining her composure as her eye's danced with pleasure. Adora knew her, knew what she was capable of. She was loving how exasperated she was becoming. That fear of the unknown would make her reckless.

"Princess Adora! The rules state clearly. That all princesses and their chosen guests are welcome. " Frosta announced, her tone was weary. She was tired of dealing with Adora.

"But they're up to something?" Adora stubbornly professed, as she turned to glare at Frosta. She had to protect the innocent people at the ball. She had to get Frosta to understand how dangerous Catra was?

Catra was loving this, it was so satisfying to watch her self-destruct her own reputation! Catra just needed to give her one good push. So she turned and stuck out her tongue at Adora. Egging her on to dig an even bigger hole for herself.

"You have too.." Adora scoffed at Catra's childish taunt and turned back to continue to beseech Frosta to listen.

"That's enough!" Frosta raised her hand, silencing Adora's further protests. "You see me as a child. But I have worked too hard to gain respect only to throw it away. Because you feel their up to something!"

Adora was livid, her brow's draw tight as she shifted her eyes to Glimmer. Paying the unresponsive Princess a pointed look. As Glimmer had just been standing there, silent, not backing her up at all.

While Catra snickered from the other side of the Scorpioni woman. Thoroughly, enjoying her being reprimanded by a kid!

"For centuries the all princess ball has been neutral ground. I will not dishonor that legacy. " Frosta continued to address Adora with contempt, punching her tiny fist into the arm of the throne. "Scorpia is a princess, princesses get plus ones…they stay!" her voice rose as she raised her arm, pointing to the roof as she spat her declaration to the heavens. Her ire rises upon every word.

Catra and Scorpia wore amused smiles, as Adora grunted in disapproval. Unable to formulate a rebuttal. Before a guard appeared and clapped both Adora and Glimmer on the shoulder with their gloved hands. Then promptly pushed them off the dais to the floor below.

They cried out in alarm, as they were rudely cast away from the throne. A crowd had gathered around the dias during their exchange. Gasped, and began whispering amongst themselves.

Having a hard time, keeping her expression impassive. Catra's ears twitched, as certain words floated in the air.

Bright Moon…such disgraceful behavior… She dishonors She-Ra's legacy.

Finishing her bow, Catra turned towards the stairs with a very pleased smile. Finding

Glimmer and Adora lay sprawled on the floor, slowly gathering themselves up to a seated position. Both of their faces were flushed, embarrassed.

"Really, Adora…I'm shocked, we are not breaking any rules. Didn't you read the invite?" Catra acted appalled. She couldn't help herself, as she swaggered down the steps and up to Adora. Hands in the pockets of her wine colored dress pants. Her expression was mockingly sad. Feign innocence, as she gloated at Adora abject humiliation in front of everyone she had been seeking to impress tonight.

"I know you're plotting something. From now till the second the ball ends, I'll be watching…wherever the two of you go…I go." Adora was undeterred from her duty. She proclaimed her intention's with a cunning determination, that she wasn't going to allow them to get the better of her.

"Suit yourself. " Catra shrugged " Have fun, with following us.." Catra taunted, as Scorpia took her cue and walked off in the opposite direction of Catra.

Catra's ear flicked, as she giggled with amusement. When she heard Adora's frustrated growl.

Tonight was going to be so much fun!

Adora

Hour Two…

She was not having a good time! This whole experience had been awful. She had felt awkward in this dress! Wearing something so constricting was not natural for her. She had been wound up tight

as a bow string since she first entered the ballroom. She was nervous and humiliated and stressed and furious and…and…and

Catra had been making a fool of her!

Leading her around in circles, as Adora barreled through the crowds valiantly attempting to keep up to the sly cat. Terrified at what diabolical plan she might have for tonight. There were too many people here, too many that could get hurt. While Catra was acting completely at ease, tossing snacks from random waiter's platter's into her mouth. Stopping just long enough to stay out of Adora's reach, smirking and waving at her mockingly. Before she weaved effortlessly through the throng of party goers, disappearing from sight. Just as Adora would catch up to her, leaving her high and dry and scanning the ballroom frantically. Only to find the feline on the other side of the ballroom. Leaning casually against a pillar, scanning the ballroom as if searching for something, hands once more stuffed suspiciously in the pockets of her pants. As if she was hiding something…

Adora narrowed her eyes in annoyance.

She was driving her crazy!

Adora had been chasing her around for half an hour, now! Clenching her fists and growling in frustration, she stormed across the dancefloor once again. The waiter Catra had just taken food from, took a step back from the blonde with a wary look. As Adora loomed behind Catra, menacingly like a storm cloud about to strike.

"Adora…you have got to try this." Catra announced eagerly, spinning on her heels and stuffing several crackers topped with some salty cream into her mouth. That she had stacked seconds earlier into a moderate sized tower.

Adora had no time to react, on instinct she complied as the mouthful of cracker's was crammed into her mouth. Catra's cackle

of delight rang like bells through the ballroom. Drawing the attention of everyone around them. As she then sauntered away, leaving Adora looking like an ill mannered glutton. Her cheeks puffed out and struggling to chew and swallow the obnoxious amount of dry crackers. Infuriated by the fact that Catra had been two steps ahead the whole time and had gotten the best of her again!

Insufferable brat!

Catra moved briskly down an open colonnade and then disappeared through a narrow archway, hands once again deep in her pockets. Looking absolutely suspicious!

"I got you now!" Adora growled, with a slow triumphant smile. Charging after the magicat, disappearing through the archway in pursuit.

Adora sucked in a sudden breath at what she found beyond the archway. She never explored beyond the ballroom, even though there were dozens of these archways both on the main floor and above along the upper balconies.

It was a tiny sitting room, glowing icicles descended from the high ceilings above. Illuminating the nook in soft, serene light. The outer wall is completely made of ice.

Offering a panoramic view of a wide open, outer courtyard, that resembled more of a natural plateau. With the backdrop of the rocky, snow covered crags of the mountain range, looming beyond the cliff's edge. It had been late afternoon when she had arrived with Glimmer. Now twilight has fallen around the Castle since then. Snow flurries rushed against the clear walls, dusting the lower ramparts below and the smooth parapets rising along the edges of the windows in brilliant white. The wind was singing

against the ice, a lonely, mournful song that sent shivers down her spine.

It was just so cold and inhospitable here in the Kingdom of Snows. Yet, from up here high within the central keep. She could appreciate the rugged beauty, the sheer majesty of the mountains that surrounded them.

A strange circular couch enrobed a heavy silver fur, sat in the center of the room. It looked cozy. She could easily see herself snuggling down in the center of that fuzzy nest. Under different circumstances the atmosphere might have been soothing. As it was, she was so agitated, she felt ready to snap.

Finding Catra standing before the glass, made of ice. Facing the gentle snowstorm outside, just staring at the swirling snow cascading against the pane.

Adora smiled in quiet triumph. There was no way out, the cat was trapped. If she knew it, Catra wasn't letting on. Merely waiting, her ears flipping at the soft sound of Adora's sandaled feet upon the hard floor.

Adora slowed, noticing how Catra was now holding herself. Both arms crossed protectively over her chest, gripping her upper arms tight. As if being alone with her was making her insecure? Her tail was low and wrapped timidly around her thigh. The playfulness she had out in the ballroom was gone, without an audience to pander too. She had become somber, her expression was pensive…sad…remorseful?

"Catra…" Adora swallowed hard, her trepidation about this moment was thick. It lodged in her throat and she could only utter that one word. She had been yearning for months to finally get a chance to confront Catra about their misunderstandings.

She cautiously approached her ex-best friend.

"Hey, Adora…" Catra responded in kind, turning to her with a weak smile. Her forehead resting against the cold surface of the

ice wall.

Adora’s gut churned with anxiety and her heart was beating rapidly in her chest. As doubt and distrust began to rise inside of her. Catra had been faking her out all night? Was Catra really being introspective right now, or was it just an act? Could she really be honest and heartfelt with her right now or who would her attempts to reconcile be met with contempt and rejection?

“Why are you here?” Adora sighed, leaning her shoulder against the window. Regarding Catra with a skeptical frown. Taking the chance, maybe she could fix them. If she took this slow, if tested the water first before opening up completely.

Catra merely shrugged, avoiding Adora’s gaze. By maintaining her focus on the snowstorm outside.

“You hate crowds, you hate being cold…you hate Princesses…” Adora continued, flipping up her fingers as she recited all the reason’s Catra would have avoided this whole thing from the start.

“I was doing Scorpia a favor. She wanted to come and she needed a plus one..” Catra finally snapped her eyes away from the storm to confront Adora with a pointed glare.

“How chivalrous of you?” Adora chuckled.

Catra never said a word, just flipped her off instead. As an awkward silence fell around them for a long time.

Adora sighed, she had been trying all the old tricks, to incite Catra to banter back with her. But it hadn’t worked, she had shut down instead.

“I know you, Catra. “ Adora, began. “Which is why it's so hard to understand why you're still with the Horde?

“You don’t know me! “ Catra threw her head back, as a harsh, almost violent laugh erupted from her throat. “Not anymore..” She

finished with a low snarl, her eyes piercing with unspoken accusations of how Adora had failed her as a best friend.

“That’s not fair.” Adora retorted, quietly. Unable to really refute it, their friendship had been strained for years. Another bloated silence fell between them.

“Why didn’t you come with me….” Adora's voice was small, unable to stop her lower lip from trembling.

“Why didn’t you come home!” Catra shot back, fully seething now. With her arms still crossed and claws now sheathing and unsheathing. As she struggled to contain her fury.

Adora groaned and pinched the bridge off her nose. She was frustrated and disheartened by the roundabout of this conversation. Why couldn’t she figure out how to get through to her!

Catra merely sighed, a long and burdensome groan finishing her expelling air.

“It’s great to see you too.” She commented snidely.

“Really, Catra.” Adora crossed her arms over her breast and scowled down at her. In the end she couldn’t put her hurt feelings aside.

“Whatever…Princess…” Catra returned, stating her title as if it was a poisonous slur. Refusing to look at her, keeping her eyes solidly on the frozen landscape outside. She looked sullen, her hands pushed deep into her pockets now. Closed off and sulking.

“I didn’t ask to be a Princess!” Adora huffed, both indignant at Catra, yet also proud at how it all turned out. “But honestly, it’s been the best thing to ever happen to me. “ She defended vehemently. Then grew timid, scuffing the toe of her sandal on the floor, nervously. “Can you say the same, at becoming a Force Captain?” She challenged more softly, As all the fire inside her, simmered down at how despondent Catra was. She curled her

hands into fists, instead of reaching out. She wanted desperately to infold Catra into her arms and hold on tight. She couldn't help but feel powerless, knowing her best friend had been slipping away more and more every day. But she once again stalled with showing her true affection, unsure how it would be received after everything that has happened.

Adora once again never saw the hurt her words caused Catra. As the magicat took a deep breath, biting her lower lip with a fang to keep the sob inside.
"Fine!" Catra snarled, whipping away from the glass and stalking across the room.

"Catra…wait…" Adora pleaded, knowing she had just screwed up again somehow.

By the time she had left the room, Catra had disappeared into the crowds.

"Fuck!" Adora ground out, rushing into the center of the ballroom. Spinning in slow circles as she scanned the crowds for the magicat. It took several long, anxious minutes for Adora to finally spot her again.

Finding her slinking behind a pillar, then tossing something into a waste basket. By the time she had run across the vast room and slid on her knees to the basket, dug around, only to pull out a piece of paper that had "Hi Adora' written on it. Her cheeks were blazing with renewed humiliation. Catra had been hunting for a garage pail all this time just to prank her! Giggling nervously, at how foolish she looked yet again. As the crowds nearby were once again whispering and offering her concerned, yet also confused looks.

Everyone had thought she had lost her mind!

Dammit Catra !

Adora was now hovering in the corner of the lower dance floor. Scanning the endless crowds for that elusive magicat. She had given her the slip, again! Cursing how gullible she was. Catra had lured her to a garbage bin at the edge of the ballroom and dropped something mysterious inside. Adora of course fell for it and scrambled to dig through it in case it was a bomb or something. Adora growled in frustration…balling her hands into fists at her sides. Even after all her studying and preparation for this night. She was still making a huge mess of this! She completely screwed up her greeting with Frosta. With how standoffish and irritable the girl was being with her. The young monarch probably hated her at this point. Glimmer was useless, stuck in her head about Bow coming with Perfuma. She was worried about her, but she sucked at pep talks, was even worse at consoling someone ... .and Catra was making her look crazy in front of the Etherian royals! Could this night get any worse!

Catra

It was easy enough to get back on mission. Sinking back into her anger and spite. She didn't care what Adora thought about her, or her choices. She would show her exactly what she was capable of!

Luring Adora around the ballroom again and finally finding a waste basket to toss in her latest taunt Delighting at how easy it was to torment the blonde. She slipped away into the crowds, knowing that Adora would take the bait, because she always thought the worst of her.

It was the intoxicating smells that drew her over the buffet table on the far side of the ballroom. She had already sampled a few horderves from the platter's being walked around by server's.

They had been delectable, so it was natural that this long table carved from ice, full of a colorful assortment of foods and glass bowls of drinks, would draw her attention.

Being Scorpia's plus One had its perks!

She grinned eagerly, as she scanned the platter's of tiny delights. She had managed to get her hands on real food from time to time growing up. But this…this assortment of oddly shaped items, topped with all kinds of things was overwhelming in the best of ways. So obviously, she started sampling, shuffling down the table taking what she wanted, nibbling on a few then a few more of the ones she liked, or sneering with disgust and setting the partially eaten ones she didn't like back on the platters. Finally, reaching the end of the table with a platter that only had a few little pastry's left. She snatched one up, taking a tentative bite since the last one she ate that looked like this had tasted awful. Finding this one was sweet, yet salty…with just a hint of something savory. Perhaps it had meat in it? It wasn't fruit…or even a custard…Her eyes dilated as she hummed in delight, ready to grab another one. Only to find them all gone?

She looked around briefly in disbelief, just as a long purple lock of hair snaked up from below the table. Snaking around the nearby platter, snatching up the entire assortment of tiny food items and hauling them away.

"Hey!" Catra backs up a step, crouching down and glaring at the thief hiding under the table. Finding an odd looking woman, dressed in coveralls. She was older with incredibly long purple ponytails. Completely engrossed in a tape recorder.
"Princess ball, hour 2.15 minutes and thirty seven seconds. The social experiment is going rather well, overall. I have made extensive notes, observing a wide range of emotions. Subject:Glimmer has been the most intriguing to watch. Her emotional state had been in constant flux all evening. She really is having difficulty adjusting to Bow and Perfuma's 'friendship.' I believe she has transitioned from hurt feelings to jealousy….further observation is required. "

“What are you doing?” Catra folded her arms over her chest in irritation.
“I’m gathering data.” Entrapta answered, “Adora has become emotionally erratic …since your arrival? Please, explain why?” Thrusting the tape recorder at her.

Catra chuckled ruefully and crawled under the table to join her.

“She’s a neurotic, overachieving idiot, who sucks at improvising, when things don’t go according to her plans.” Catra shrugged, “So, I ‘love’ messing with her.”

“Your friends then.” Entrapta nodded.

“No…I…” Catra stumbled, ears pinning back and glancing awkwardly down at the floor. “She is not my friend…she used to be…but…It’s complicated.” She finally admitted, reluctantly.

“Ah…I see..” Entrapta, took in every small nuisance of Catra’s reaction. Her amber eyes, calculating and logging how Catra shifted uncomfortably, how her eyes dropped down in regret. The hurt and anger simmering just under the surface.

“So…Princess Scorpia has replaced Adora in your friend column? ” Entrapta, noted after a long silence. Completely oblivious, or uncaring that Catra had pilfered a tiny cake out of her food pouch and was currently nibbling on it.

“I don’t make friends.” Catra offered, crisply. Her eyes scanned the milling crowds absently.

“Neither do I.” Entrapta answered bluntly. With no hint of emotional attachment to the statement beyond stating a fact.

They shared a small, reciprocal smile between them.

“I never had a research Assistant before…this is fun.” Entnrapta commented with a small, tentative smile.
“You know, you can’t really see the whole ball room from down here. How about we go up to that balcony and observe everyone

from there?" Catra pointed up to the ice railing above the ballroom.

"Your logic is sound. Shall we depart then, oh….bring snacks! " Entrapta waved a ponytail outward, in invitation for her to come with her.
"I'll be right behind you." Catra smirked, ducking out a minute later and grabbing a couple more tidbits from the restocked platters for the road.

Kyle

They had trekked deeper into the mountain passes, leaving the Scorpiion Cruiser hidden on a wide heath several miles back. Moving into a rock formation near a low crag near the peak. Needing some natural cover to set up a sniper's nest. Kyle busied himself setting up the tripod and methodically adjusting the settings of the scope. While Lonnie lounged nearby on the cold ground, leaning against a boulder, that abutted against the mountain's jagged ridge they were camped out on.

They were both dressed for the colder elements, in heavy gray and red accented Horde issued jackets, black leather gloves and boots. It had helped a little to keep the bitter cold at bay, but being in the elements for close to two hours they were both shivering.

"Fuck, Kyle how much longer…I'm freezing my ass off here?" Lonnie complained, shoving her hands into her armpits as she fought off the chill, that by now, she swore had seeped in her bones.

The faint light of twilight had become murky, as nIght was falling over the mountains. The temp was dropping rapidly from merely cold to down right frigid.

Kyle merely grunted, in response. Slowly, panning the scope over the Castle in the distance. He had been at this for close to an hour. Searching for a clear shot at a couple sentries. That was supposed to be stationed on the south-western tower, near an open courtyard along the upper ridge of the Mountain, Castle Chill was built upon.

“Seriously, Kyle!” Lonnie huffed in irritation, rising to her feet and roughly shoving Kyle aside to look through the scope for herself.

“I’ve been trying to find the tower Atila had shown us on the schematic of the castle but I can’t find it!” Kyle whined, unlatching his pad from his utility belt and reviewing the computer generated image of the Castle.

“Show me where it's supposed to be?’ Lonnie sighed, all she could see was smooth, covered spires and endless covered ramparts of ice.

“Ok…” Kyle huffed, latching the pad back on his belt. He clutched the shoulder brace in one hand and placed his hand on top of the scope. Eye’s narrowed in concentration as he used the rifle's long mussel as a pointer to show Lonnie there were no open spots in the entirety of that wretched Castle of snow and ice.

“We got the central gate house…” He pointed the scope to the lower keep that stood sentry at the end of the ice bridge. With the massive ice shaped portcullis deep inside that was now closed. Then he guided the scope upward to the larger inset Keep behind the gate. “See that huge snowflake, window?” He pointed the scope towards the central keep at the upper reaches of the Castle.

“Yeah…” Lonnie muttered, pressing her eye tighter to the soft plastic cradle on the end of the scope.

“That’s the ballroom..ok…Where going South…then west, now.” He swiveled the rifle on the tripod’s adjustment ball.

“It’s solid ice…is that the upper battlements?” She questioned. “How the fuck to they defend that? There's no openings for cannon’s or even flat, open ramparts for ballista?”

“Yep, then we are to go up…that’s where there is a guard tower and supposedly there were open battlements to land the Cruiser?” He advised with a grunt of frustration.

“No…the spires are all sealed and if there were battlements… they're not there anymore.” Lonnie answered.

“Exactly! So either Atila lied…or that Castle of Ice’s architecture can be changed?” Kyle tapped a boot impatiently.

“Either way, we're improvising now. Pack up!” Lonnie scrambled to her feet. “We are running out of time, we gotta infiltrate that Castle.” She ripped her stun baton from her belt and began to adjust the settings. As she headed back down the trail to the Scorpion Cruiser.

Kyle groaned in dismay, as once again fear of the unknown crept up his throat, strangling his voice. He disassembled his rifle in minutes and was on her heels.

“What’s the plan!” He shouted, jogging down the narrow trail that wound down to the wide heath below.

“Don’t got one, we’ll figure it out as we go.” Lonnie shrugged, as she mounted the ramp into the back hold of the airship.

“Wonderful….” Kyle grumbled, tossing his rifle bag onto the floor and unlatching his own stun baton from his belt. As the back hatch hummed to life, the ramp pulled up sealing the back of the aircraft tight.

Princess Prom

Hour Two and a half…

Adora

The whole night had gone to hell, in a matter of minutes. She had scrambled to get up to the balcony when she saw Catra, skulking toward Entrapta. It looked like the cat hybrid was going to push the tecmaster off her perch. Ended up, Catra had made friends with the Princess of Dryl over petty theft. Which was very on brand for Catra. She then had a very frustrating conversation with Entrapta, who seemed to have forgotten all about joining the Alliance and had no clue that Catra was the BAD GUY! Then of course! Catra disappeared again! The very second she was distracted…

Then an announcement of the first dance, further drew her attention away from finding Catra. As she was quickly swept up by the crowds down the stairs to the dance floor. She had been practicing this traditional dance for a month. She had felt so confident that she was prepared for everything. But now she was agitated from chasing Catra around all night and losing her again! Nervous about having to perform this overly complicated dance. A traditional dance of unity, in which the guests moved between partner's in a series of hand clasps and spin's. To signify the various kingdoms coming together in peace.

Then Catra finally appears, as her first partner. Offering her gloved hand with a sly, smug smile. Her mismatched eye's narrow in silent challenge, for her to take her hand. Knowing she was winning, that she had been driving Adora absolutely nuts, all night!

Adora had turned away with a huff, debating if she wanted to accept. It would be like admitting Catra had won…this round…at least. In the end, Adora reluctantly took her hand with a growl.

The mood lighting dimmed and then multi-colored spotlights began to criss-cross over the dance floor as the orchestra began to play, flowing harmonies.

"I don't know about you, but I am having a blast." Catra was taunting her. Thoroughly enjoying making a fool of her all night.

Hands lightly pressed together and held high as they began to sway.

"Whatever it is you're planning, it won't work!" Adora vowed, her eyes burning with contempt.

Turning in a circle, the multi-colored lights illuminating them in blues and pinks.

"You sure.." Catra quipped, as they lightly held each other's waists turning in circles.

Adora spun away, grinding her teeth in frustration. As Catra was alluding to mischief that she may or may not wrought tonight. Adora was struggling to remain calm, as anxiety built inside her chest.

Finding a very distraught Glimmer was going to be her new dance partner.
"I got into a fight with Bow and he won't want to be friends with me!" The Princess of Bright Moon tearfully explained. As Adora spun her, now concerned about what had happened in her absence. While she was chasing Catra around.

"And I don't know where Scorpia is!" Glimmer finished in a frantic rant. As they moved into the next movement, pressing their hands together and raising them high.

"What!" Adora gasped in horror. "Glimmer don't…" She didn't get to finish as Glimmer danced away to her next partner and Perfuma moved into place in her stead.

“Have you seen Bow?” Perfuma asked, her voice soft and slightly concerned. Hopping into Adora’s arms, so she could hoist her up above her head. “He went to get his cumberbun, but that was a while ago?” She continued, as Adora spun her in a circle. “At about the same time that Horde Princess left.” She finished, as Adora set her down.

Her heart was now pounding, “Wait…did you mean Scorpia?” Adora attempted to ask, just as Perfuma spun away to her next partner and Glimmer moved back to take her place.

“Glimmer when did you last see Bow?” Adora took her hands from behind as they swayed together.

“A while ago…isn't he with Perfuma?” She confessed tearfully.

“No, Perfuma says he’s been gone this entire time!” Adora explained in rising dread, as they switched positions. Twisting Glimmer under her arm and crossing their arms to rock back and forth away from each other.

Glimmer gasped in fright, as she turned away to continue the dance.

Adora had no time to react as Catra slammed into her chest.

“Maybe, my plan won’t work…” She taunted, turning to regard Adora with a teasing smile. “Then again….” She proclaimed menacingly, narrowing her eyes. Before turning out of Adora’s chest and lunging for her hands. Clutching them tight before suddenly swinging her down into a deep dip. Straddling her bare leg and bearing down upon her like a predator “Maybe it already has…” Catra was inches away from Adora’s face, leering with pride.

As all the pieces began to fall into horrible place.

Adora’s eye’s flew wide, clutching Catra’s shoulder. As her heart slammed against her chest. She had been too slow to figure it all

out. Catra had been in control of her all night…now she was in a weak and vulnerable position beneath her.

Catra pulled her up and swung her outward. "Say, Where's your friend…Bow?"

Adora lost her control. Terrified by what Catra was capable of she snarled and lunged. Tackling her to the floor. Where they rolled, vying for dominance until Catra slammed into an ice sculpture.

The orchestra immediately stopped and the guests surrounding them gasped in horror.

"What did you do to him!" Adora accused, standing over Catra with a dangerous glare in her eyes.

"Nothing permanent!" Catra laughed, callously.

Adora reached down and hefted her up off her feet by the lapels of her suit jacket.

"Tell me what you did with him!" She demanded, holding Catra up near her face.

As the magicat, merely sneered. Silently, insighting more fury from Adora.

But before Adora could continue her very aggressive, very public interrogation.

Frosta intervened. Shooting ice crystals between them, separating Adora from Catra. As Adora was forced to let her go, as the ice formed around her and swiftly encased her inside.

Catra

Catra enjoyed watching Frosta once more put that arrogant 'hero' in her place. She just sat back, smirking as she listened to the Princess revoke Adora's invitation and banish her from the kingdom forever. Then the ballroom rumbled before the first set of heat bombs went off. Exploding the ice above Frosta's pompous looking throne.

Chaos reigned in a matter of seconds, as the Ice Palace began to fall all around them. Frosta attempted to take control of the panic now spreading across her precious ball. As the floor trembled and heaved, the walls and ceiling came crashing down around the fleeing guests.

Adora was quick to instruct Glimmer to find Bow. She disappeared with a nod. Which Catra really didn't care too much about, she slunk over to the ice now imprisoning Adora and leaned casually up against the side with a smug, victorious smile.

"What did you do!" Adora demanded from the other side of the ice.

Catra rather liked seeing her on her knees, trapped and helpless.

"I did nothing, Scorpia, Lonnie, and Kyle on the other hand?" She confessed, "We're very busy. It was fun distracting you though." She crouched down and gloated with a cackle.

"This isn't a game, people are going to get hurt!"" Adora pounded on the ice, valiantly trying to get Catra to see reason.

"It's never been a game to me!" Catra responded, balling her hand into a fist as she declared her intentions. "I'm after something bigger and no one is going to stop me!" She prowled back to Adora's ice cage and scratched her claws down its smooth surface. Illustrating to the 'hero' her determination to win… become someone powerful. She wanted to prove her worth to Hordak. To show Shadow Weaver that she had made a mistake, choosing Adora. When she was obviously more capable and superior to her in every way.

Just as a pillar fell and crashed on top of Adora's cage. Catra took that as her cue to depart and ran off to the rendezvous point.

The Castle was falling apart all around her, as Adora chased her out of the ballroom. Down the violently trembling corridors and out into a small open courtyard.

Catra was truly enjoying herself, there was nothing more invigorating than blowing stuff up! Her blood was pumping and her heart was racing with the adrenaline high she only got from life or death situations. She hadn't felt this alive since Scorpion Hills. When she had been just a cadet and was in the crosshairs of two Scout's laser rifles.

"Ha..Trapped." Adora huffed in triumph.

As Catra reached a dead end, the magicat merely turned with a cocky half smile.

"You wish." She spat back, her eyes narrowing as she spotted a piece of broken ice floating up from the ground. She placed her hands on her hips and then jumped. Allowing her instincts and her cat reflexes to rebound off the side wall of the corridor and onto an ice block, leaping up to the next one floating above it.

Watching Adora with confidence that she was going to get away. As the 'hero was left far below, scrambling to find her own way up.

Catra sighed in resignation, that this wasn't over yet. When Adora leaped through a hole in the wall and onto her own floating ice block outside the Castle walls.

Just as Catra reached the peak of the central keep, Adora leaped upon her.

Catra grappled her and with swift, smooth movements she tossed Adora aside. The blonde never was very good at hand to hand

combat. But the blonde also never stayed down or gave up. So as expected. Adora came at her again, only to have Catra clasp her hands and swing her out over the edge of the roof and toss her aside again.

Thus they were once more. Caught up in their own form of dancing…grappling and wrestling, throwing elbows and punches… vying for dominance, determined to win…

Adora cried out in frustration, as she got back up and lunged at her again. Catra merely sighed, side stepping easily out of her reach and twisting away. To laugh arrogantly at how slow and blundering her attempts were to subdue her. Leaping into the air, with her hands in her pockets. Flipping over Adora's head just as the blonde cocked a fist to punch her. Landing on Adora's back and slamming her face first into the cold, hard ice. Before rebounding off of her into another flip, only to land on the very edge of the roof. Waiting with a smirk, as the blonde wobbled back up to her feet. She came at her again, rushing her with a right hook. Catra easily ducked and dashed away, spinning on her heels. To cock her elbow and attempt to slam it into her self righteous face!. Adora sidestepped and Catra's momentum had her sailing right off the edge!

She was shocked, as her bare feet hit the thin air. Her eyes widened and her stomach dropped as her heart lurched in her chest in sudden fear. Then Adora's hand clasped her waist and pulled her back in. Catra was stunned, confused. She had saved her? Why….they were enemies?

Now she was the one in the vulnerable position below Adora.

As the blonde clutched her dress shirt and scowled down at her, inches away from her surprised face. Their heavy breaths mixed, puffing in hot rapid bursts against each of their faces. The shock and juxtaposition of their dominance wiped the snarl right off Adora's face. Ss she hovered wide eyed and breathless above Catra. Suddenly, a strange anticipation tingled inside Catra's heart.

Adora was so close…their fight had been so exhilarating… arousing…was she…

are they gonna…kiss? Then all the fragility of their perch on the edge of the keep was lost. As the roof trembled and they both fell. The brief moment of connection, shattered along with the roof of the keep.

Adora took action, pulling out her hair pin and jamming it into the ice wall. It dug in just enough to slow her to a stop. When Catra fell in front of her, she reached out and clasped her hand.

Catra finally opened her eyes, when she felt Adora gripping her hand.

"Hang on, I can get us out of this." Adora promised, her eyes were steel. Determined as always to succeed no matter the odds.

But Catra could hear the rear rotar's humming just below the clouds beneath them. Scorpia no doubt had seen their fight atop the keep was coming to get her.

"Oh, Adora. I don't want you too." Catra confessed softly, one way or another she would make Adora understand. That she would no longer allow herself to be overlooked, underestimated or subservant. That she didn't need her anymore. She twisted her hand out of her grasp and fell into the clouds.

"Catra!" Adora grasped in fear, calling out to her as she disappeared below.

Adora

"See ya, later ... .Princess."

Even now, hours later. Catra's final words were still ringing in her ears. Each callous, taunting word, stabbing her deep. Leaving her feeling lost, in fresh heartbreak. Confusion was a raging storm inside her chest. It was like she had never known Catra at all? When did Catra become this? Ruthless…this spiteful? Hell bent on hurting her…as much as possible. The pure satisfaction gleaming in her eyes, the gleeful smile and triumphant laughter. As she left her hanging upon the Keep of Castle Chill. As she flew off with her sword, with Bow and Glimmer. In that strange bug shaped airship. To her knowledge the Horde never possessed any kind of aircraft?

Thankfully, she wasn't hanging there for long. A sentry guard stationed along the northeastern ramparts had seen her. Quickly alerting Princess Frosta to her predicament. The child monarch had paused drawing magic from the Fractal Flake to repair the Castle. To come to her rescue. She rushed out of the main gates and promptly conjured up an ice platform from the bridge itself. To lower Adora back down to the entry steps of the Gatehouse below. Then promptly left her, Frosta was livid and she had far too much to deal with right now. She never even looked at Adora, which only furthered Adora's shame. Disappearing back inside the Castle and leaving her standing before the gates, with silent tears running down her face

Slowly being crushed by the weight of her failures. With a snarl of absolute frustration with herself. She rushed down the steps, she needed to get back to Bright Moon! She had to report to Queen Angella about what had happened to her daughter and Master Archer Bow. She needed to get a new sword or perhaps a bow staff, since she was more proficient with it. As it was a death wish to sneak into the Fright Zone unarmed.

Adora glanced down at the console dials embedded into the dash of the Runner. She had seen this jury rigged monstrosity in the lower parking lot when she reached the bottom of the ice bridge. She could recognize Levi's workmanship anywhere.

Catra had left the keys still hanging from the ignition. It wasn't like her to just forget something like this. Unless it was on purpose. Adora knew she had left it for her, a safeguard to make sure she had a way to travel back to wherever she wanted to go… Bright Moon or the Fright Zone.

Either way, Catra knew she was coming and she would be waiting, she would be preparing . She wanted Adora to follow…and she would, when she was prepared to confront Catra again and win.

Adora had been fighting back even more tears as she drove, sniffling and rubbing a finger under her nose. She refused to break down in the middle of the night, as she drove through the narrow, treacherous mountain passages, back down to the wide open fields of frozen tundra, heading southward. Towards the deep green embrace of the Whispering Woods. Her face was cast in an eerie green glow, from the holo-map displayed on the center column between the driver's seat and the passenger side of the vehicle. Her eyes are wet, tears pooling but no longer falling, her gaze firm, now filled with determination. Pushing all the emotions, currently at war inside of her aside. Needing to stay focused, stay the course...she had a duty to Queen Angella. Emboldened by her resolve to get back to Bright Moon, give her report to Queen Angella before heading out to the Fright Zone to save her friends. She would overcome, she would prevail...she would do what needed to be done to claim victory over the Horde...over Catra.

Part Four

Chapter Notes

> Thank you Pink Storm for your comment. I am currently working on Kingdom of Secrets, a little at a time. No where near ready to post unfortunately. I am at the half way point or more in the Tapestry of Time series..at least Finn's portion of it. Things get twisty when you are writing a time fic...lol. I am needing to stay focused on 'The moments between' fic right now. I have a lot of small side stories I want to tell before continuing the main fic. Soooo....many ideas!!! LOL. Also thank you to all who have left kudos.

S1E9:No Princess Left Behind

Adora

Adora made her way beneath the angry gray sky, buffeted by the howling winds. The low rumble of thunder, echoing from far away. Threatening her steps, with the rain storm to come. The sudden explosive sounds, jolting her body with adrenaline. As the storm slowly inched closer to Bright Moon. She was moving at a brisk jog, her pony tail snapping behind her like a whip. Dressed in her white long sleeve shirt and dark pants. Having opted to wear her combat boots instead of her sneaker’s for her evening run. The weather had been turning ugly as the afternoon wore on and she wanted to be prepared for anything. Also needing the added traction as she had every intention to be running on more rugged terrain.

Traversing the narrow trails, along the forested foothills of the Northern side of Sky Dancer Mountain. She wove through the heavier growth of fir, pine and spruce, ducking low branches and

leaping over thick, gnarled roots. As the hearty forest clung to the near vertical sides of the mountain.

It was gloomy amid the trees, the overcast sky creating an eerie almost ghostly hue beneath the canopy. Her breath was labored, coming in short powerful bursts. As she had been running for over forty-five minutes. Having exploded full speed, from right out the western gates on the other side of the island. Reluctantly, her pacing had slowed, when the trail grew more narrow and overgrown. A heavy cushion of dried needles crunched under the steady pounding of her boots. Having to watch her footing, as she rounded sharp corners along the route. As the underbrush could be slippery on a dry day, with the heavy mist soaking the trees and making the ground slick the trail was even more treacherous. The last thing she wanted was to add to Queen Angella's stress. So tripping or sliding off the trail and spraining her ankle or worse was not an option.

Racing headlong, down the worn path refusing to slow anymore than she had to for caution's sake. As she climbed and bounded over massive boulder's, wedged into the open ridges. Only to disappear back into the green veil of forest on the other side. As she made her way downward towards the open plateaus near the shoreline.

The exertion finally, pushing the displeasure she felt towards herself aside. Her critical inner monologue mercifully drowned out by the wind, the roar of the water, slamming against the rocks and the sudden crash of thunder.

The forced peace was welcomed, after enduring a restless night and endless hours of training. This was the only way she knew of to find solace, when she was so lost inside her own head. When punching and combat practice just wasn't enough to purge the endless round of doubts about her own worth. She needed to just run!

She started looking for the side trail, when she reached the top of a small rise. The forest was thick and the cutoff was small and

easily overlooked in the faded, dim light of dusk. Its visibility was made worse by the mist. She slowed just a little more, as she scanned either side of the trail.

She didn't want to miss it. It was the only path that would lead her downward out of the trees and onto the wider, more open shoreline. If she missed the diverging trail and remained on the one she was on, it would just lead her back around to the gates. The castle was not where she wanted to be right now.

Queen Angella was still so distraught and agitated from all that has happened in the last few days. The stately woman didn't rage or scream, like Adora was used to. When she would have to face judgment for her failures back in the Horde. The tall, angelic woman had instead kept silent, brooding through the halls. As she fretted over Glimmer's well being. The princess had been avoiding her mother since they got back from the Fright Zone.

Adora could see the sadness and displeasure in the queen's eyes every time they ran into each other. Before and after the mission to the Fright Zone. She knew the queen was disappointed in her. That she had failed to protect her friends at Princess Prom…to protect her daughter then and in the Fright Zone.

With every bend in the trail, Adora scanned for the cutoff. Pushing herself onward, looking for that fork. Sweat ran down her back, making her moist shirt cling even more to her clammy skin.

The forest path was a blur, as she took that sharp bend to the right. Now, headed towards the jagged plateaus at the very edge of the island. That hung, like sheer cliffs over the turbulent waters of the lake below.

She had promised to get Bow and Glimmer back…only to have the Princess Alliance's first mission turn out to be an absolute nightmare! None of them were trained for combat let alone infiltration! Adora spent more time compensating for one blunder after another. They should have trained together these last few months, so they could fight cohesively like a proper strike team!

What was even worse was that Glimmer was glitching. She was hiding from her mother, which made the Queen frantic with worry. The tension in the castle was razor sharp and Adora couldn't stand to be within its walls.

She was frustrated, angry and so very disappointed in herself. She had been She-Ra for only a few months and she was messing everything up!

Adora glanced up, as she broke free of the treeline. Staring ahead at the open sky. As the storm rolled in over the edges of Half Moon lake. The sudden bursts of lightning on the horizon. Illuminating the darkness in flashes of brilliant white, was jarring and exhilarating at the same time. Her eyes flared wide at every strike. The turbulent atmosphere suited her dark mood just fine and Adora found herself finding a kinship with the building storm.

Charging across the open field, her fists clenched tight and arm's pumping as she shot across flat stones covered in moss. That was all embedded into the hard packed earth, like natural flagstones. She was focused, staring unblinkingly forward.. Racing the storm, determined to reach her destination. Before the sky released the torrential rainfall, it had been building for the last half hour.

Pushing herself to run faster, run harder, run…just run…until her chest ached more from exertion than the crushing grief.

Adora grit her teeth…she was such a terrible leader…

One mission…One, and the Princess Alliance was disbanded. They had lost faith in the Alliance and retreated back to their own castles again! Unable to deal with the loss of one of their own.

Entrapta…was gone…

Her plan's once again had gone sideways and she and her team were left improvising. Leading to another death…that was all her fault. A heartbreaking reminder of her failures back in the Horde, of losing Louis. Proving once again what a terrible strategist she was. That Adora in the end would never be good enough, she

wasn’t smart enough to foresee every angle that might go wrong and compensate for them accordingly. Nor strong enough to keep people safe…when things inevitably spiraled out of her control.

She moved steadily across the plateau, disappearing into the rocky shoreline that jutted over the lake. Heading towards a natural rock formation, of several weathered pillars. That rose out over the very edge of the plateau, like worn down teeth rising from the jaw of some mythical beast.

She had found this refuge during her evening run’s many weeks ago, now finding herself pulled to these circles of stones regularly. As the stress of being She-Ra mounted. A high up, wayward sanctuary, not unlike the platform she retreated to with Catra so long ago.

Soon she began to weave into the field of stones that creeped along the edges of the northern plateaus. Sky Dancer Mountain was at her back, hidden within the mists. While Half Moon Lake rose before her, as a massive expanse of churning water that faded quickly into the evening gloom as night began to fall. The jagged treeline of the Whispering Woods was further away on this side of the island, becoming nearly invisible within the curling fog. That was now hovering over the shoreline, further obscuring her course. Soon the circle of Guardian stones loomed around her, ascending like pillars of obsidian. Smooth, ancient monoliths, rising up into the forbiddingly bleak sky. The deafening roar of the waves crashed against the pillars, sending bursts of lake water into her face.

She finally stopped, heaving for breath and pacing in a small circle within the confines. Finally hidden and alone she could pull down her barriers and allow her weakness to show. With her hand’s braced on her hips, she struggled to contain the misery that wished to rip from her throat. In shattering screams and heart wrenching sobs. In the end, only whimpers through clenched teeth and silent tears were shed.

Adora squinted every time the cold spray hit her cheeks and neck. Relishing the sting of the freezing water. She looked up, finding the brooding clouds now overhead, blanketing the sky all the way to the horizon. This ugly weather mirrored her mood perfectly and she was reluctant to go back and find shelter inside the castle. She sat down against one of the rocks, pressing her back against the smooth surface and awaited the storm to break over her head.

Sitting in the rain suited her just fine…

As the storm closes in, they haunt her…those she left behind…

Her friends...her bunkmates...her Strike Team…

"You think you can just come back here!" Lonnie growled, swinging her stun baton.

Adora blocked her attack with her bow staff, the rush of the platform ascending rapidly. Sending her stomach into her toes, as she rushed into battle to defend her friends…from….
"I need to save my friends." Adora had declared.

"We were your friends!" Lonnie countered, the crackle of electricity arcing from the stun baton, illuminating her angry face. The hurt and betrayal clear in her hazel eyes, as she pushed Adora back.

Her best friend…Her confidant…Her Catra…

"This is not because I like you." Catra offered the hilt off her sword, eyes firm and unwavering. As she met Adora's confused

gaze for only a moment before glancing away. Her pensive resolve, turning into a stoney expression…devoid of any and all emotion.

Adora sighed, leaning back against the stone and raising her face up to the dark sky. Haunted by so much of what happened in the Fright Zone. As the sky opened up, the rain pelted her hard and fast, drenching her whole body in a matter of moments. Yet she stubbornly remained seated upon the ground, as the soil became waterlogged and muddy. The guilt and regret was crushing her and she just wanted to feel numb. She had lost so much…in such a short time… She had failed and Glimmer and Entrapta had paid the price. She was making a real mess of all this…she didn't know how to be She-Ra…she didn't know how to fix any of this!

Catra

With the evening came the wind, howling across the desolation that lay beyond the fortress. The sand storm battered the outer rampart walls with a vengeance. Turning the sky a dark blood red, like a freshly clotted wound. Catra couldn't bear to go back to their platform after everything…it just hurt too much. But the towers near the forge were not lacking in other platforms for her to find refuge on. She quickly scaled one of the taller towers further east of their sanctuary, to a completely open platform with no safety railings at all.

Gravitating to the more risky perch and the life threatening danger it poses.

She had been disappearing regularly to the higher platforms near the Forge, since Adora had defected. Needing to be alone and

brood. Ever since the Princess Alliance had invaded the Fright Zone. A boiling rage was constantly churning inside her, like a destructive maelstrom.

All around her were the macabre towers, cutting into the violent sky. Swaying against the gale force of the wind. As she sat on the very edge of the platform, seemingly unconcerned about the storm currently barreling down upon the Fortress. With one leg raised to lean an arm over her knee. The foot braced upon the metal rim, had her toe claws fully extended, to dig into the metal rooting her in place. The other dangling over the edge, swinging lazily in the wind. Her other hand was braced behind her, finger claws as well dug deeply into the platform to hold herself in steady. As her tail was curled around her thigh, the very tip twitched. In sharp, angry flicks. Her ears pinned back, protectively against her head. As the wind was too strong. The precarious structure groaned under the bombardment of the wind. Her dark brunette mane was whipping over her back, as she closed her eyes basking in the thunderous roar that sought to deafen everything…even her tortured thoughts. The violence of the wind mirrored her mood and she was going to bask in its painful embrace, for as long as she could.

Sitting here on the edge…defying the wind…that threatened to toss her off this precipice to her death… suited her just fine.

"Report to the Force Captain's barracks and pack your things. Now that Adora is back, there is no need for you there." Shadow Weaver stated, in a matter of fact tone.

Catra snarled, gnashing her sharp teeth in contempt. Even after everything she had done to prove to that old woman that she was worthy of being a Force Captain. That she was better than her precious Adora!

But, it was Adora, she wanted…always…Adora!

She was a traitor and a liar!

Why! Damn it hurt…she hated how much it hurt!

To be cast aside…like she didn't matter…like she was worthless…

Why wasn't she good enough!

Catra was drowning, in the white hot rage once more. Screaming into the wind. All the vitriol she kept inside for so long towards Shadow Weaver, towards Adora. Spewing forth, purging herself of its poison in one long, vengeful cry of pure unadulterated hate!

The look of pity Adora had given her, when Shadow Weaver cast her aside, expelling her from the Black Garnet chamber…it was infuriating! Adora always made her feel weak, unworthy and pathetic…

Her spite flared deep inside of her, searing her heart. Burning away the last of her compassion towards either of them. A thick, ugly scar would cover her heart. Forming an armor, so tough that it would never break again. She made promises to herself. That she would prove herself…superior to both of them. She was going to show them both, how strong she truly was.

She didn't need them…she didn't need anyone…

S1E10:The Beacon

Catra

" Going somewhere?"

Catra had been so caught up in packing her backpack, for her mission to the Whispering Woods to retrieve First Ones tech for Entrapta. She never heard the door to her quarter's hiss open and the lurking presence of Shadow Weaver until the old crone had pointedly addressed her.

"Like I'd tell you." She responded, "I've got a lead on something big and I am not going to let you take all the credit again." She chuckled, ruefully "Not that it worked out so great for you the last time." Enjoying Hordak once again, threatening Shadow Weaver and watching the old crone cower. With a gloating smile, Catra turned to confront her commanding officer. The smug smile evaporated instantly at the sorry state she found the old sorceress in.

As Shadow Weaver leaned heavily against the bedpost, shivering and short of breath. Catra knew instantly that Hordak had punished her severely. For allowing the Princess of Bright Moon to escape and for also losing the Sword of Protection. Catra felt no guilt about what happened to Shadow Weaver. She would never allow that old crone to erase Adora's memories. She needed a little vengeance as well, after her humiliation inside the Black Garnet Chamber. So she had cut the power to Glimmer's restraints. With the feed to the Black Garnet severed, Glimmer was finally allowed to teleport. Setting in motion, Shadow Weaver's karmic reward and their escape. Giving Adora back her sword…well…after Shadow Weaver had discarded her for Adora. She now had to make sure the Golden Child had no reason to stay. She needed her gone…wanted her gone!

"Don't worry about that thing with Hordak. I've got loads of experience being yelled at. Mostly by you, actually." Catra couldn't help but feel sorry for her guardian, having endured such grueling punishments herself. So she had unconsciously reached out yet again, to console her only motherly role model. "You get used to it." She shrugged and slowly stood up, swinging her pack over her shoulder.

Shadow Weaver snatched her elbow just as she walked by. "I will not get used to mediocrity, like you! And I certainly do not need your pity!" She snarled, curling her fingers around Catra's arm in a vice-like grip.

Catra recoiled, her eyes wide in surprise that she had strength to retaliate. But not surprised at all by the old woman's venom. The hurt in Catra's eyes was brief, twisting into a defiant glare.

Shadow Weaver let go, glancing down for a moment reflecting. "I was hard on you, I won't deny it and I won't apologize." She sighed, heavily. "I just wanted to prepare you for the world. I wanted you to be strong." The conviction in her voice was unwavering.

"Yeah, well congratulations I'm plenty strong now." Catra moved towards the door, "and I don't need you." She finished with finality as she passed through the doorway and disappeared into the gloom of the corridor beyond. Without a single look backwards.

Adora

The enormity of Glimmer's agony while glitching fell upon Adora, with an avalanche of guilt. The fear and desperation, making her impulsively jump into action. Causing her to leap right out of the princesses window and rush in the Whispering Woods for aid. She needed to find the Beacon, she had to find a way to heal her…she needed to learn about She-Ra…find that woman from her vision…

The Whispering Woods on the other hand was less than helpful.

Moving through the endless labyrinth of ancient trees, with the shrubbery grabbing her cape and low branches always getting in

her way. The woods seemed to be slowing her down…blocking her way forward…leading her in circles!

"Just let me fix this…please!" She-Ra pleaded to the woods, in frustration. Moving past the rock she had marked hours previous and into a small glen. She had been walking for hours and going nowhere. "I can't let anyone else get hurt!"

The woods remained silent, as she reached out and touched the rough bark of a nearby tree. Seeking unconsciously to connect to the magic that surrounded her. Glancing around the branches above, hopeful.

But once again the woods stood, impassive and unresponsive to her entreaty.

Waiting…

"Fine…you win." She-Ra faded into Adora, "You want me to be weak!" She accused the forest with a snarl. Pulling the sword from its leather sheath on her back and tossing it away. "I am…" She crumpled to the ground, pulling her knees up and ducking her head away into her crossed arms in defeat. "And I'm afraid...because I am no good at any of this." She admitted, barely holding back the tears. As her fear and heartbreak rushed over her, now that she had allowed herself to be open, to feel.

A light flared ahead of her. She snapped her head up, tears drying. Scrambling to her feet she moved towards the light, filtering through the leaves of a wall of shrubbery. As the woods finally allowed her to find what she had been searching for.

The beacon…

S1E11: Promise

Catra

She had practically run back to her quarter's after handing off the First Ones Tech to Entrapta. Only slowing down for a moment when lower ranking soldier's passed her in the corridor's. Forcing herself to walk, back straight and scowl firmly in place. So not to raise suspicion that she was barely in control of herself.

Once safe inside her room with the door locked, she had burrowed under the old blue blanket on her bed. Wrapping Adora's faded, almost extinct scent around herself. As a wall of grief and remorse slammed into her, taking her breath.

(*She was gone…)*

Her whole body began to shake violently as the shock finally set in. As she finally allowed her armor to fall. With a broken, shuttered sob she ripped her mask off her head and flung it angrily to the floor. It clattered away into the darkness of her room, as the Day Moon had yet to rise. The sheer power of her emotions rose to consume her. A tidal wave of sorrow and disbelief rushed over her. Making her heart pound against her chest. Gasping and shivering under the flimsy protection of Adora's blanket. She wallowed in the trauma of what she had gone through, the brutal choices she made.

(What have I done…)

Catra keened miserably, ears pressed flat to her head, as tears streamed down her face. Squeezing her eyes shut tight, clenching the fabric around her neck as she curled up tight into a small ball.

(I killed her…)

The realization struck her cold, freezing the breath in her lungs and causing her heart to stammer and lurch with guilt and regret.

Catra turned and pressed her face into the firm mattress screaming in both rage and despair. Suddenly light headed and dizzy. She took as deep of a breath as she could, but the sound was strangled and broken. Succumbing to her tortured feelings, sobbing and screaming into her mattress for hours. Until she fell into a restless, light sleep that was plagued with her guilt, her resentment and her rage.

"Can I ask you something? :" Adora questioned softly, as they slowly made their way deeper into the First Ones Ruin.

"Can I stop you?' Catra groused, rolling her eyes in disdain. Nearly stumbling over the side of a bottomless pit. When they entered a cavernous room, filled with doors and a solitary pillar crossing the chasm.

"Why did you help me escape, after Shadow Weaver captured me?" Adora inquired, as they stood before the pit. Her expression was confused, hopeful.

"Not this again." Catra moaned, striding ahead and leaping up onto the pillar. Intending to leave Adora behind.

"It's the one thing I can't figure out?" Adora followed. "You didn't have to do that, you could have gotten caught. Why risk it?" She jumped down after Catra, when they reached the other side. Having to rush to keep up, she misjudged her landing and lost her footing. The edge crumbling away from beneath her boot. With a yelp she started to tumble backward, only to have Catra reach out and grab her arm.

"You think I would just let Shadow Weaver erase your memory like that?" Catra pointed out.

"I don't know, probably." Adora answered, as she clung onto Catra's wrist.

Catra huffed and pulled her back up. "Yeah, well. You never did have too much faith in me."

"Can you blame me." Adora shrugged, admitted that it was true.

Catra scoffed, "Not really." She turned and strode away, her tail curling around Adora's wrist tenderly.

Adora smiled, at the subtle affection. Hope shone in her eyes, that this time she could convince Catra to follow her to the Rebellion.

"I had it!" Catra snarled, she had just saved herself from that spider. When Adora just had to swoop down and take that victory from her! Like always!

"Let's stay together from now on." Adora ignored her outrage, picking off a spider web from Catra's shoulder.

"Would you stop telling me what to do!" Catra exclaimed furiously. Slapping Adora's hand away from her shoulder.

"What is your problem?" Adora challenged from a lower ledge. As Catra finished her final leap to the corridor above. "I was trying to save you?"

She spun back to confront her, seething. " For the last time. I don't need you to save me, I've been doing just fine on my own. No thanks to you."

Catra never really slept that night, but dawn brought a new clarity.

Staring out of her small window, her eyes puffy and red rimmed from crying. Her mind no longer lashes her…she had spun for

hours in misery, then self loathing, then finally settling on excuses as to why it had been necessary. Why Adora had deserved it...how she had brought that upon herself. Repeating an endless round of assurances, that she had no choice, That she had to get rid of Adora..it was the only way…to make sure her ambitions came to fruition. The only way for Shadow Weaver to notice her… see her worth…be able to prove herself to Hordak. The only way for her to finally show her potential…Her worth would no longer hinge upon Adora!

In the predawn, she was finally numb, her mind quiet and contemplative about where she went from here. Adora was gone…so too was She-Ra. She had no one who could really stand in her way from taking everything she wanted.

She was finally free…

She had finally had the courage to stand up to Adora.

"You always need to play the hero. Don't you!" Catra accused, throwing Adora's guiding hand off her shoulder.

"I was only trying to protect you." Adora answered honestly.

"You never protected me! Not in any way that would put you on Shadow Weaver's bad side!" Catra responded vehemently, waving her arms at her sides in protest.

"Admit it! You loved being her favorite!"

"That's not true!" Adora responded, her voice cracking with emotion.

"Oh, yeah! When you left, who took the fall for you then." Catra poked her accusingly in the chest. "Who was protecting me then?"

She stated, heatedly. Pressing a hand righteously against her chest.

"You don't have to let Shadow Weaver treat you like that anymore. You can leave!" Adora defended. "Just like I did."

"Oh, Because I need to follow you. Everywhere you go!" Catra pushed her away and stormed down the hallway. "I don't want to leave!" Catra turned, seeking desperately for Adora to understand. "What don't you understand about that? I'm not afraid of Shadow Weaver anymore and I'm a better Force Captain then you would have ever been. " Her declaration was ardent and full of pride, at what she had already accomplished without Adora at her side.

"You always said you didn't care about things like that?" Adora amended, her voice soft and repentful.

"Well I was lying…Obviously!" Catra shouted, painful tears now streaming down her cheeks. Proud, yet also heartbroken at finally confessing her own wants and desires to Adora. Knowing she had kept them hidden, but so very disappointed that Adora never truly noticed her, never cared enough to see her worth. Catra wouldn't allow Adora to console her, turning around and walking off.

"Catra Wait!" Adora rushed after her, grabbing her by the shoulder in desperation.

Catra pulled her hand away sharply. "Why do you think I gave the sword back to you in the Fright Zone. I didn't want you to come back, Adora!" She admitted, turning and striding off. Unwilling to stay…this time it was her turn to leave, to break their promise. To break her ex-best friend's heart and leave her to pick up the pieces alone…

All the festering resentment and disappointments had come to light. Able to tell her the truth about how she really felt, exactly what she thought of her. That it was her fault that Shadow

Weaver treated her so horrible growing up. How she had failed to protect her.

“Hey, Adora.” Catra cooed softly, pacing up to the edge off the cliff. Smirking bitterly, as she ran a claw down the blade of Adora’s sword. Her eyes were impassive, cold. As she stared down at Adora. Who hung from a spider web, below her clawed feet.

“Catra, help me…please.” Adora breathed in relief, staring up at her with hope shining in her eyes.

“This thing won’t work for me, if I tried…would it?’ Catra wondered, her eyes keen, calculating as she slowly scrutinized the ornate, broad sword in her grasp. “It only works for you.” She surmised, flourishing the blade outward. “Then again…you're special. That’s what Shadow Weaver always said.” She continued, her tone flat. Not making any movements to aid Adora at all.

“Catra…what are you doing?” Adora questioned, her voice wavering as she finally began to doubt that Catra would save her.

“Ahh…it all makes sense, now. You’ve always been the one holding me back. “ Catra turned with a sly smile, walking away. “You wanted me to think I needed you. You wanted me to feel weak.” She sighed and turned back, coming back into view above Adora. “Every hero needs a sidekick, right.” She growled, staring down at Adora with disdain.

“Catra…no. That’s not how it was. “ Adora shook her head, her arms had grown tired and were now trembling. Her grasp slipped slowly down the slick webbing, as Catra continued to let her hang there over the dark pit.

Catra started to laugh, a bitter, rueful cackle. As she crouched down. “The sad thing is, I spent all this time. Hoping you would come back to the Horde. “ She leaned an arm on her knee and braced her weight on the sword. Lightly clutching the hilt, with the blade pressed downward into the edge of the cliff. “ When

really, you leaving was the best thing to ever happen to me." Her voice turned cunning. As her pupil's grew small, a fierce… predatory gleam grew in her eyes.

Adora gasped in fear, never having had that malicious gaze ever directed at her before.

"I am so much stronger than anyone ever thought." Catra spoke softly, callously drawing the blade over the spider webs. Slowly and insidiously cutting away Adora's life line. Adora's one hand released her eyes pleading…terrified as the webbing went slack.

"I wonder what I could have been, If I got rid of you sooner?" Catra bit her lower lip, enjoying how weak and vulnerable Adora was beneath her. How the mighty hero was brought low and at her mercy…a mercy she would never give!

As she finished cutting the web, Adora screamed. Falling several feet down, her right hand desperately catching a tiny ledge.

"I'm sorry…I neve meant to make you feel that you were second best. Please don't do this!" Adora sobbed, calling up to her in a desperate plea for forgiveness.

But Catra was deaf to her sorrow. Standing above her in victory, her face cold and impassive. Then with a triumphant grin she tossed the sword over the side.

"Bye, Adora. I really am going to miss you." Catra called flippantly, with a hand braced on her hip, severing their connection to each other with a spiteful smile. Relishing every moment of her victory. As she turned and swaggered away.

Finally she had done it! Adora knew how much she had hurt her as they grew up. How much she had grown to loathe her! She had proven just how strong she had become, that she didn't need her anymore!

She was free!...of all that pain…of that anger…

The light cathartic feeling lasted only a few moments, as a slow revelation set in.

Because there really was no way that the place built for She-Ra would honestly allow her to be killed…

Catra finally took a deep breath, a small weak smile of relief spreading upon her face. She would have another chance…

S1E12:Light Hope

Catra

"Noooo!!!" Shadow Weaver howled, casting wrathful shadow's in every direction. Destroying the screens mounted along the walls of the Black Garnet Chamber.

"Stop her! Don't let her touch.." Catra yelled, as Shadow Weaver prowled towards the Crystal.

"You will not take, what is mine!" Shadow Weaver declared, her claw like hands pressing against the Black Garnet crystal. Drawing its magic into herself through red arcing lighting, cascading out from its core and down along her arms. As the shard in the forehead of her mask began to glow along with her eyes. A frightening hum grew from the center of the crimson pillar. Rising

into a crescendo of a thunderous wail as the sorceress drew back from the crystal fully charged to attack.

Scorpia prepared herself, having endured the Sorceress's dark magic many times as a child. When she had displeased Shadow Weaver, during her brief time under her tutelage. After her mother's and Grandmother had been killed. As the sorceress sought to have her bond with the Rune Stone. That stubbornly refused to accept her and remained dormant. So Scorpia grit her teeth, resolved to protect her friends as she growled and charged the crazed sorceress.

Shadow Weaver bellowed in wrath, red lighting crackling menacingly around her. As she hovered at great speed towards Scorpia. Her eyes burning with rage, as she threw a wall of shadow's and lightning at the Scorpion woman, holding her in place. Scorpio grit her teeth, her muscles tight and burning from the Black Garnet's magic.

Terrified and frozen she could only dart her eyes in panic, as Shadow Weaver continued her assault upon her friends.

Entrapta cried out in fear, scrambling with Emily, to get away from the Garnet and hide behind her equipment nearby. Only to be frozen against her bot by Shadow Weaver's red lightning. The numbing sensation coursing through her body was intriguing…but painful!

As Catra ran to the far end of the chamber, only to have Shadow Weaver throw shadows and lightning towards her. Caging her momentarily, the magicat leaped over the wall of shadows. Glancing over her shoulder to gauge the mad woman's next attack. Landing on a set of pipes near the roof and quickly leaping onto another set. Keeping ahead of the malicious shadow's seeking to grab her.

"That's right! Run away…that's all you've ever been good at!" Shadow Weaver taunted.

Catra landed behind the Black Garnet only to have the piece of equipment that was attached, snatched away by her shadows and flung at her. Catra was agile and she was fast, able once more to stay ahead of the old woman's assault. Leaping away just in time, as the metal arm came crashing down into the floor. Rending metal and buckling the joists below. "You have always been a disappointment, you've learned nothing from me." The old woman shouted, slamming her hands into the floor and sending another barrage of shadows towards Catra.

Catra kept leaping away, rebounding off more pipes to land on the far side of the room.

"Oh, no. I've learned everything from you." The magicat snarled, crouching with a fist. Her leg muscles primed to keep moving. "How to predict when you'd strike" She weaved around a shadow, dancing out of the way of another. Keeping her eyes darting to all the corner's surrounding her as she dashed back behind the Garnet. "How to dodge, how to resist!" She declared, in a defiant snarl. "You thought you were punishing me all these years." She turned and began to climb the crystal, as the shadows coiled and surrounded the Sorceress. Intending to use the old woman's blind rage against her. "Wrong." Catra called above the impenetrable gloom Shadow Weaver had created within the chamber. "You were training me for this day!" She lunged off the peak, claws extended. Coming down hard and fast upon the shocked and surprised crone who had lost track of her in the darkness.

Shadow Weaver cried out in pain and horror, as Catra slashed her rune shard shattering it.

"Nooooo!" Shadow Weaver howled in desolation, falling to her knees. As the shadows she commanded finally dissipated for good.

Releasing Scorpia and Entrapta.

Catra had won…again…she had never felt stronger, or more alive! More proud…more safe… than defeating her greatest tormentor.

Watching with smug satisfaction as the old woman scrambles desperately for the shattered remains of her power. "Come, back to me…come back to me…" Shadow Weaver whimpered… pathetically at Catra's feet.

S1E13:The Battle of Bright Moon

Adora

Nearly a week after the battle…

The aftermath of the Horde assault on Bright Moon had been exhilarating and joyous. They had beaten the Horde back, saved Bright Moon. The Princess Alliance had unified and their magic had all harmonized…It had felt so powerful…so vibrant and so pure…when she channeled all that magic through the sword. The waves of mystical light had destroyed the darkness…, thwarting Catra's plans to destroy the Moon Stone. Then miraculously She-Ra's magic had also healed Glimmer! The Moon Stone had shone more brightly than ever before. In the days that followed Adora came to find out from the Princesses that their Rune Stones had been recharged as well. Etheria's magic was balanced once more.

She had finally gotten it right! With the help of all her new friends. For the first time in months, Adora had hope that she could do this. She could protect Etheria.

Then slowly the euphoria faded and the grim reality of what they faced now began to take hold. She fell into a bleak, despair. Mourning all that she had lost. She never left her room, unwilling

to train, reluctant to eat. She was just numb…wallowing in a daze, trapped in a state of emotional paralysis.

Glimmer and Bow visited often, attempting to raise her spirits but it never worked. It was Perfuma's visit this afternoon. That resulted in a long, enlightening talk, about feelings and how powerful they can be and methods to help ease and work through them. In a more healthy way than avoiding them. By punching things and running till you drop from exhaustion…

Adora had been pacing around her room in endless circles, sleep had been eluding her tonight. She stopped before the massive glass door's that led out to her balcony, arms crossed and expression pensive. Her brows were deeply furrowed and eyes distant, burdened by far too many emotions. Dressed in long, billowing, gray cotton pants and nothing else. She had been unable to wear shirts ever since her fight with Catra. She-Ra magic had healed the deep gouges down her back to an extent when she transformed back into Adora. But the cuts were extensive. Going straight down from her shoulder blades to her lower back. The muscles had knitted back together but the epidermis of her skin would have to seal up on its own. So the scabs that had formed down her back kept cracking, oozing pus and blood every time she moved. Her torso was wrapped in bandages, the cloth along her back stained crimson. The claw marks she now wore upon her back would be a permanent reminder of how much she had hurt Catra. How badly she had failed her growing up. She would always wear the cost of her choices and she had come to terms with that. At least she was starting to come to terms with it.

Adora sighed, as she stared out her balcony glass. The sky was dark, the aura of magic that usually danced above the trees was mournfully absent. Illustrating how wounded the Whispering Woods was right now. The forest beyond the lake was frozen, the trees ravaged by the Horde tanks that had invaded days before.

Great swaths of forest lay broken and shattered by Horde's battalion's of tanks and bots.

She focused on her reflection, gazing back at her. From within the facets of the ornate cut glass of her balcony doors. Her blonde hair was down, cascading over her shoulders and down her back. She looked different…older…than ever before. Her eyes carried a haunted quality, the warm blue having turned a stormy gray. A distant and brooding countenance stared back at her.

Adora huffed a breath of resignation through tight lips, sliding her gaze towards her desk. A simple wooden table now sat just before the raised dais that led to the balcony. A plush stool pushed underneath. With several sheets of paper, stacked neatly atop the desk along with a quill set in a delicate glass inkwell.

Adora groaned and rolled her shoulder's, finally obeying Perfuma's order's. Resigned, if she wanted to get her mind to shut up and get some rest. She needed to do this, she needed to get it all out in the open. So she sat on the stool, hunched over the paper and tapped the white feathered quill into the ink. The action was sharp, and violent as she gathered her thoughts.

Dear Catra,

So much has changed for both of us in these last few months. I understand now, how much I have hurt you. But….

Adora paused, tapping a finger nervously on the table top. Mulling over her next words, uncertain, perhaps unwilling to put in writing her own declaration of harm. That Catra had inflicted upon her growing up. Leaving all her personal pain and resentments towards the feline unsaid.

"I can't change the past, but I need to move on from it. I have accepted that you are my enemy now and you always will be…All this time, I had hoped I could convince you to join me here…in Bright Moon. Having you here…with me..

I fantasized about showing you around the Castle, sharing all the delicious food they eat here. How much fun we would have together. Running around the halls and sparring in the Soldier's training yard. I wanted you to see that Etheria is worth protecting…but all you seem to want to do is destroy. You're angry, I get it. I am sorry, though, for everything.

Adora paused in her writing, her back ached from the bent position. Her slowly healing wounds pinched against the bandages. She stiffened her posture, rolling her shoulders to relieve the tension before returning to her letter.

I have no more hope now, that you would join me and that makes me sad. So sad. Because I miss you, Catra. I will always miss you. I miss your smile, when I made you happy, or when I did something dumb that made you laugh. I miss the triumphant gleam in your eye when you would beat me in a race or combat training. I miss laughing with you when we would play a prank on Kyle, or any of the other cadets back in the bunkroom. I miss fooling around with you in the evening after supper. Wrestling in the halls…We always found something fun to do...some meaningless competition to waste our time with. I miss your jokes and sarcasm, how you always tried so hard to make me smile when I was upset. I miss you…the most. When I go to bed…I find it hard to sleep without you. Your soft snoring up in the top bunk, that was so much like a purr…it always made me feel safe… knowing you were there. I miss just hanging out with you, talking and joking about…everything. I miss holding you up on our platform…when you were upset and needed comfort. I will miss

so much of what we once were. I will mourn what could have been…if only you had come with me.

Adora groaned, setting the quill down in the inkwell and scrubbing a hand threw her loose hair. Biting her lip as it started to tremble and allowing a tear to fall down her cheek. Then with a shuddering sigh, she picked up the quill and resumed her letter.

Those are the things I will remember, when I think about you. I'm going to remember the good instead of the bad. Because the memories we have of each other right now…they break my heart.

I'm sorry things turned out this way between us. I really am. But even if I could go back in time, I wouldn't do things any other way.

Love, Adora

She slowly stood back up, setting the quill back into the inkwell. She wandered back to staring mournfully out of her balcony windows as it was just too cold to go outside right now. Allowing the ink time to dry, before returning to the desk and neatly folding the paper. Tucking it away in a hidden compartment, under the left hand drawer that she unlocked with a small skeleton key. Perfuma wanted her to start journaling, to get out all the thoughts and emotions she refused to share with her friends. Releasing them in private, as a way to ease the turmoil in her mind. This would be the first of many entries she would make over the course of the next three years. All tucked away and hidden in her desk, never to see the light of day.

End Notes

This fic is a series of extra scenes and a deeper more emotional dive into certain more prominent scenes of the show. That illustrate both Adora and Catra's journey through out the next three years. As they figure out who they are, what really matters and that no matter...how hopeless things get, they can always rely on one another.

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